



GROOVE ACTIVATOR

Queen Edition



U S E R M A N U A L

GOTA YASHIKI

(c) 2026 GOTA RECORDS / AJITO SOUNDS

Ayabe, Kyoto

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PART I WELCOME

01

WELCOME FROM GOTA

Welcome from Gota

Welcome to Groove Activator.

The 1980s — when synthesizers, samplers and sequencers were just becoming widespread. From that era, before the word “uchikomi” (programming) even existed in Japanese, I had been chasing one question: how to fuse the groove of a live human performance with the groove only a machine can produce. In 1995, as one answer, I released a sampling CD titled “Groove Activator.”

Thirty years on. Groove Activator has been reborn as a drum plugin — carrying the ideas of that time forward, redesigned from the ground up for today’s production environment. It takes in the many features that could never fit on a sampling CD, aiming for a more flexible and more intuitive way to make grooves. I hope this plugin sparks new ideas and new expression.

Gota Yashiki
AJITO SOUNDS (Ayabe, Kyoto)
June 2026



The 1995 sampling CD “Groove Activator”

02

WHAT IS GROOVE ACTIVATOR

What is Groove Activator

The concept of Groove Activator

The delicate expression of acoustic drums, the commanding presence of an analog drum machine, and beat-making built from audio loops. Groove Activator is designed to complete this wide range of drum production inside a single plugin. Its three core modules can be used on their own or freely combined — and that combination is what produces grooves you haven't heard before.

Three core modules

Pad Sampler

The 18-pad sampler at the heart of Groove Activator. Each pad can hold multiple velocity layers and variations, reproducing not only dynamics but also natural variation between hits played at the same strength. It gives programmed drums the expression of a human performance. With an ADVANCED mode for professional work plus an easy SIMPLE mode, even someone touching a drum plugin for the first time can start making a groove within minutes.

Analog Activator

An analog drum engine designed with the world's legendary machines in mind. Play thick, present analog sounds you can't get from samples alone. It carries 14 voices — not just kick and snare but Tom, Rimshot, Cowbell, Clap, Sweep and more — and layers onto acoustic drums at the push of a button, so you can easily recreate the acoustic-plus-drum-machine sound that became a beat-making staple from the late 1980s on.

Slice Activator

A sampler that automatically slices an audio loop and lets you play each slice from a pad. Its biggest feature: you can place a sliced sound simply by copy-and-pasting it onto a drum-mic channel. Build a multi-mic kit out of loop material in an instant — turning what used to be tedious beat-making into something faster and more intuitive.

PART II SETUP

03

INSTALLATION & ACTIVATION

Installation & Activation

System Requirements

Supported environment

Tested DAWs

Installation Steps

Steps

Uninstalling

Before installing, check that your PC meets the following requirements.

Item	Requirement
OS	Windows 10 (version 1607) or later / Windows 11
Processor	64-bit (x64)
Formats	VST3 / AAX (Pro Tools 2023.6 or later) / Standalone
RAM	8GB or more (16GB or more recommended)
Storage	2GB or more free (including kits)
Display	1440 × 900 or higher

NOTE There is no AU (Audio Units) build for Windows. AU is a macOS-only format.

Tested DAWs

Pro Tools 2024 or later (AAX), Ableton Live 12, Cubase 13, Studio One 6.

Installation Steps

Groove Activator is distributed as a code-signed installer (.exe). The publisher shows as “Gota Yashiki”.

NOTE While the certificate is still new, Windows SmartScreen may say “Windows protected your PC”. Click “More info”, check that the publisher is Gota Yashiki, then press “Run anyway”. This stops happening as the download count builds up — it happens to every newly signed publisher.

1. Download the installer

After purchase, download GrooveActivator_v1.5.1_Windows_x64_Setup.exe from the download link you receive. Where that link arrives depends on the store you bought from.

2. Run the installer

Double-click to open it and follow the on-screen guide. Windows asks for administrator confirmation (User Account Control) once. The installer speaks English and Japanese.

Part-way through you can choose what to install. VST3 is always installed. The AAX plug-in (for Pro Tools), the standalone application and the sound library can each be left out.

CAUTION Close your DAW first. A DAW that was open during the install cannot see the new plug-in yet.

NOTE The “Ready to Install” page lists where the sound library and the plug-ins will go, so you can check before anything is written.

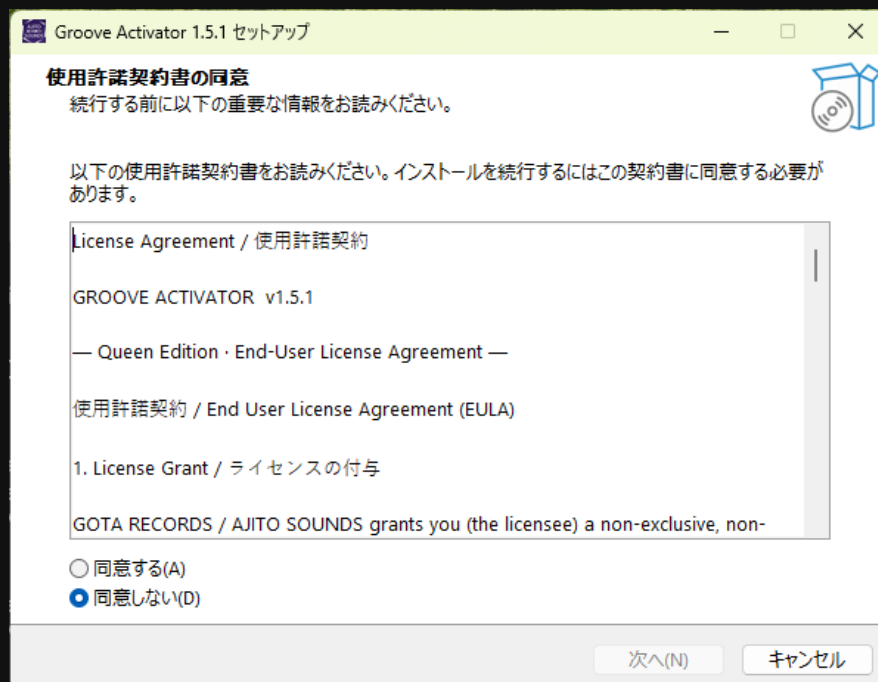


Fig 03-1 Reviewing the End-User License Agreement (EULA)

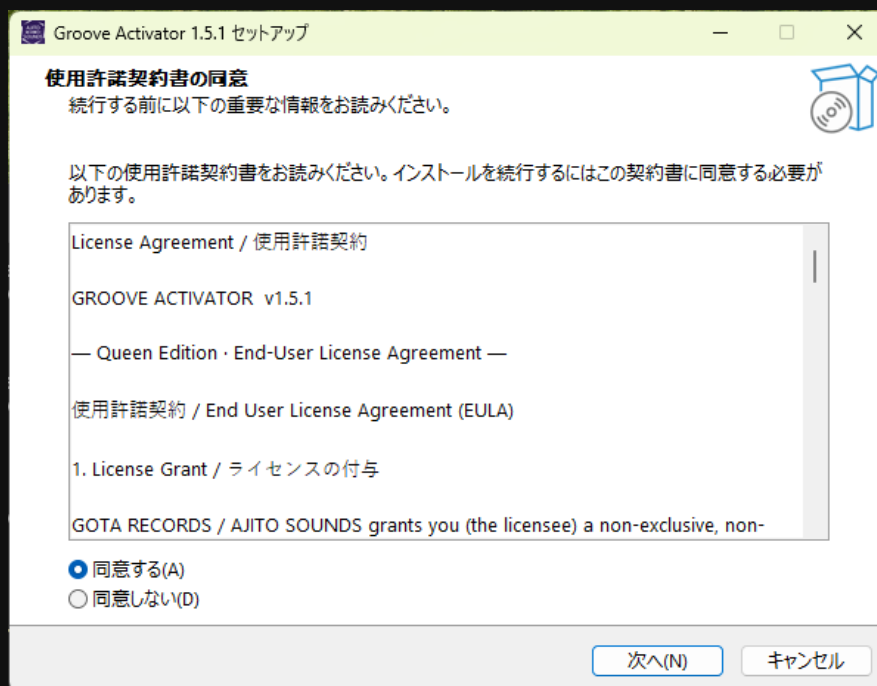


Fig 03-2 Choose “I accept”, then Next

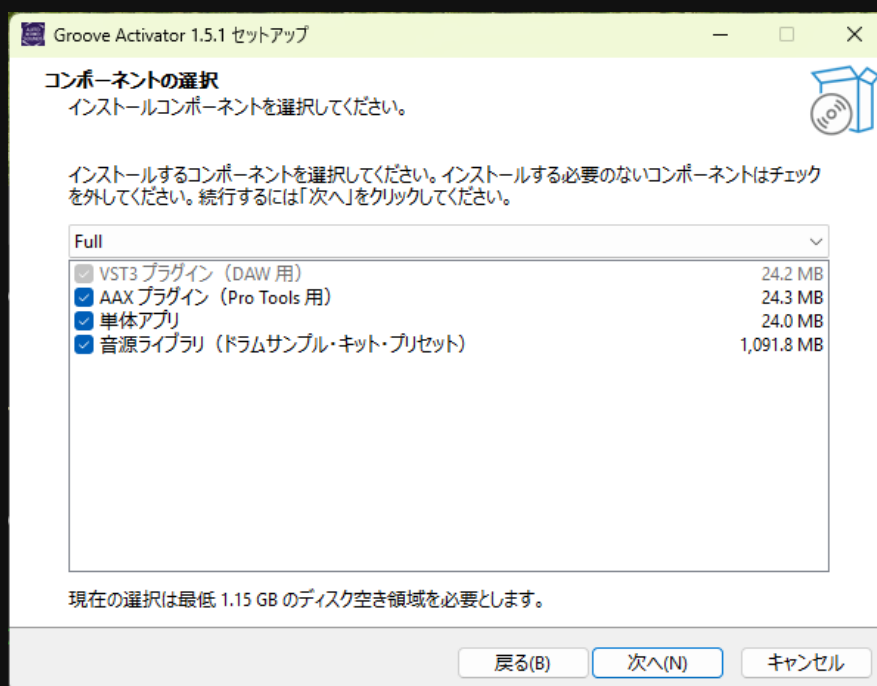


Fig 03-3 Choosing what to install (VST3 is always installed)

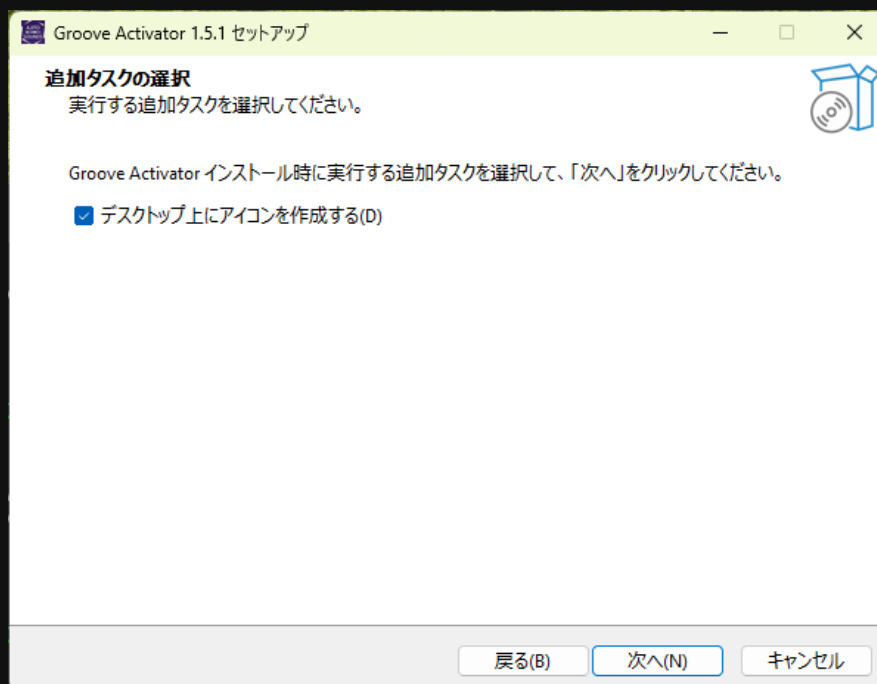


Fig 03-4 Additional tasks - a desktop icon is made only if you tick it

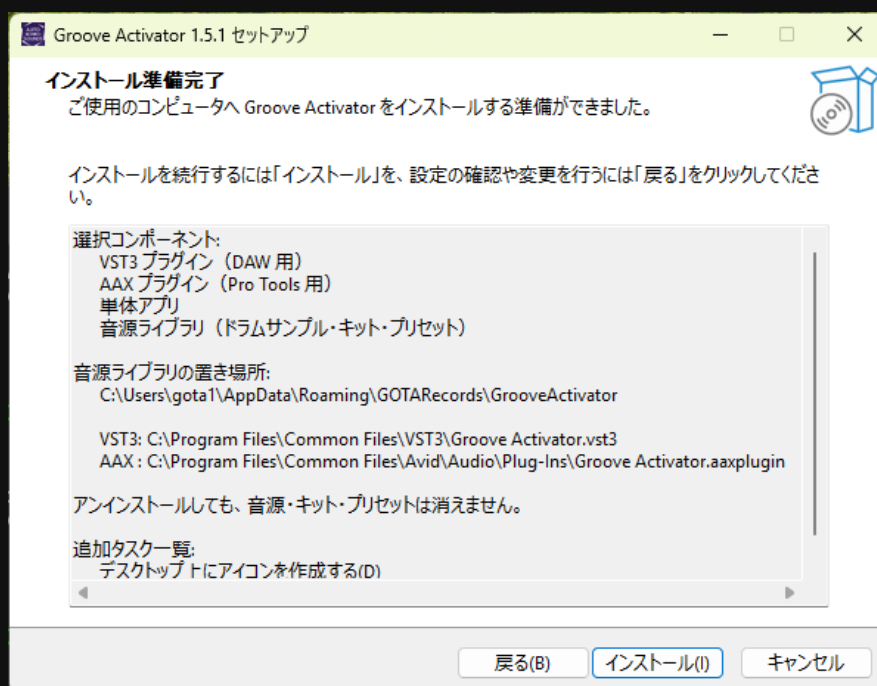


Fig 03-5 Ready to Install - where the sound library and the plug-ins will go

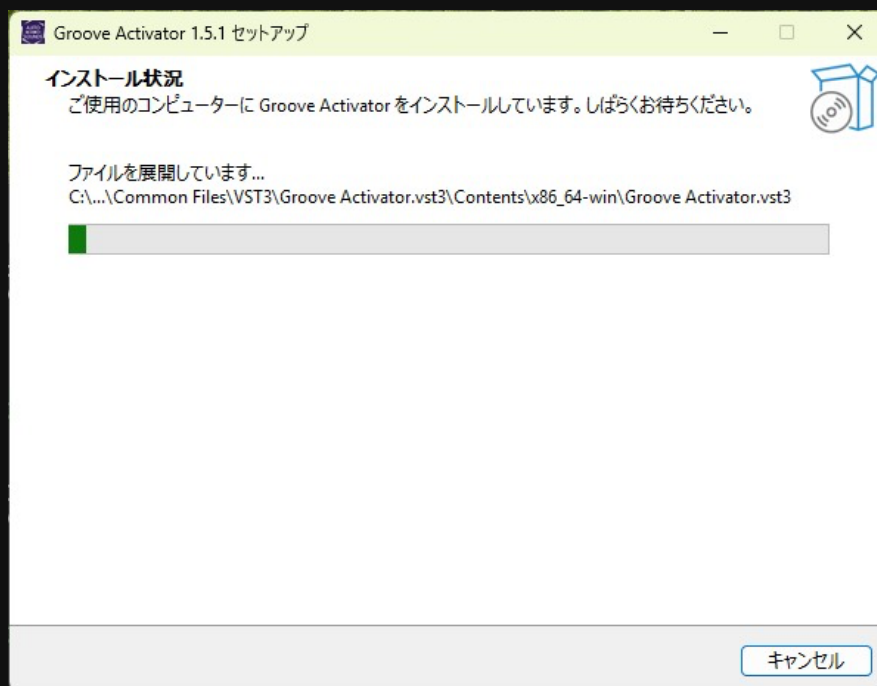


Fig 03-6 Installing (this can take a few minutes)

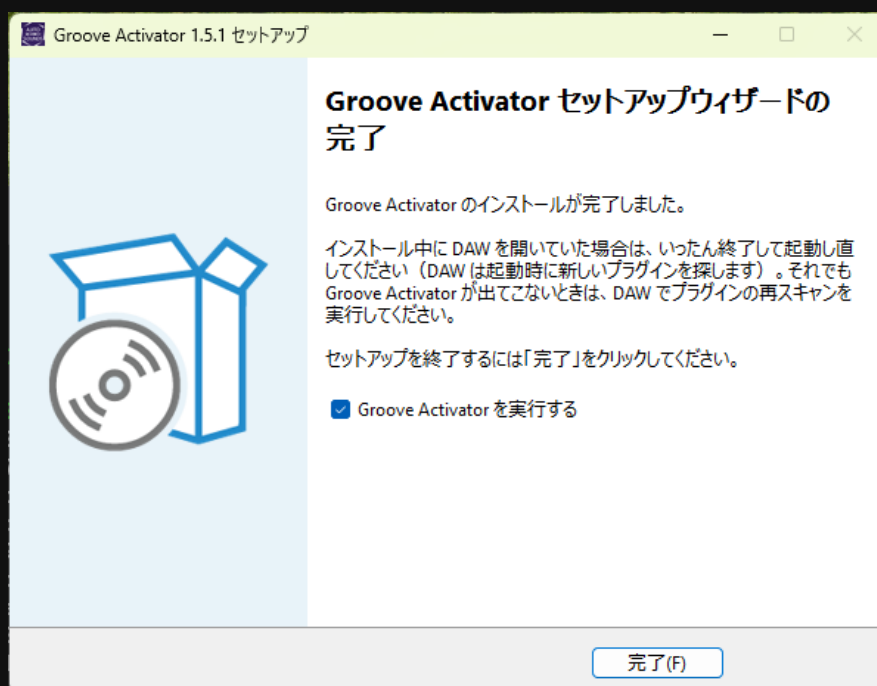


Fig 03-7 Finished - restart the DAW if it was open; rescan if the plug-in does not appear

3. Install locations

Each format is installed in the following locations.

Format	Location
Standalone	C:\Program Files\AJITO SOUNDS\Groove Activator\
VST3	C:\Program Files\Common Files\VST3\Groove Activator.vst3
AAX	C:\Program Files\Common Files\Avid\Audio\Plug-Ins\Groove Activator.aaxplugin

NOTE Choosing the standalone application adds “Groove Activator” to the Start menu. A desktop icon is created only if you tick that box during the install (it is off by default).

NOTE If the plug-in does not appear in your DAW, quit the DAW completely and start it again — it looks for new plug-ins at startup. If it still does not appear, run a plug-in rescan from your DAW's settings. See Appendix B for more.

Uninstalling

Open Settings → Apps → Installed apps, find Groove Activator and uninstall it. “Uninstall Groove Activator” in the Start menu does the same thing. The standalone application and the VST3 / AAX plug-ins are removed.

Only the application and the plugins are removed. The kits and settings you created remain intact in the user-data folder below.

```
%APPDATA%\GOTARECORDS\GrooveActivator\  
Kits/           Kits  
Pads/           Exported Pad / Layer Packs  
Presets/        Presets  
Sets/           Sets  
Samples/        Samples  
Grooves/        Grooves (.mid)  
Manual/         Manual PDFs
```

NOTE Slice Activator and Analog Activator presets, and the loops you load into the Slicer, live in this same folder. (On macOS they sit in a separate place; on Windows there is only one.)

If you want to remove everything by hand, delete that folder in File Explorer. Typing %APPDATA% into the address bar takes you to its parent.

License Activation

Groove Activator is activated with the serial number issued at purchase. You activate once — after that it runs offline, permanently.

Steps

1. Launch

After installing, launch the plugin (or the Standalone app) for the first time and the License Activation screen appears.



Fig 03-8 The License Activation screen (first launch)

2. Enter your serial number

Type the serial number from your email — in the XXXXX-XXXXX-XXXXX form — into the Enter Serial Number field. Copy & paste from the email is the most reliable way.

NOTE Input is auto-corrected: lowercase becomes uppercase, and you may leave the hyphens out. The easily-confused I / L are read as 1 and O as 0, so just type what you see.

3. Press ACTIVATE

Press the ACTIVATE button. “License activated!” appears and every feature is unlocked.

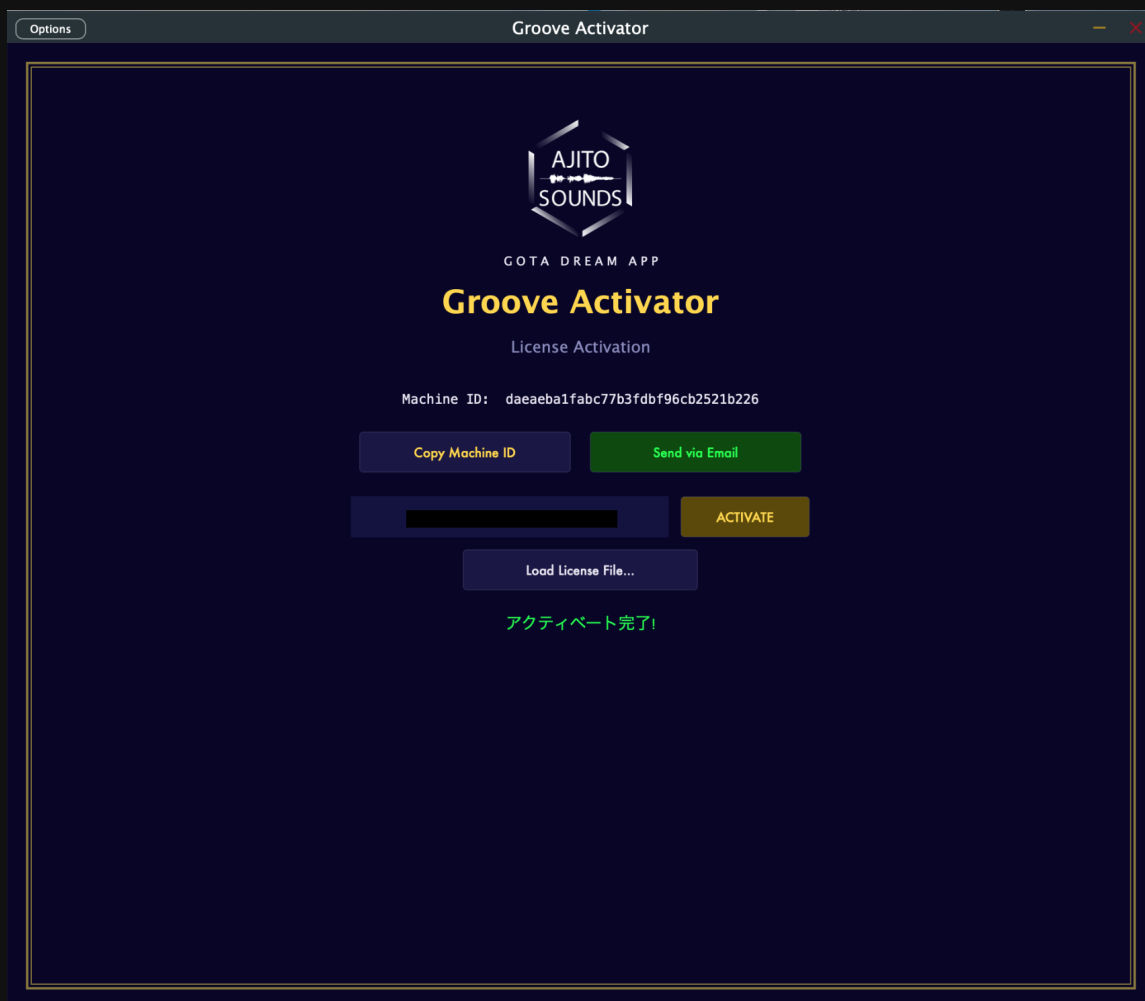


Fig 03-9 Activation complete

After activation

Your activation is stored on this PC and survives restarts — and even uninstalling then reinstalling keeps the license intact (see Ch.21).

NOTE One license may be used on up to two (2) machines — Mac and Windows in any mix. If you need to re-activate after replacing or repairing your computer, contact support below.

Machine ID and support

The Machine ID shown on the License Activation screen identifies your PC. If you have lost your serial number or activation fails, contact support with that ID.

NOTE Testers and reviewers using a license.json distribution can still activate the traditional way via Load License File... on the same screen.

If you bought it from Plugin Boutique

Your serial number comes from Plugin Boutique. Look for it in the confirmation you receive and in your Plugin Boutique account. Entering it, and everything after activation, works exactly as above.

NOTE The software is identical whichever store you bought it from. Only where you get the download and the serial differs.

04 FIRST SOUND IN 5 MINUTES

First Sound in 5 Minutes

For anyone who just wants to make a sound right now: with Standalone you can hear Groove Activator in about five minutes, without even opening a DAW.

1. Launch the app

Start Groove Activator from the Start menu (or double-click its desktop icon, if you chose to create one during installation). After license activation, the main window appears.

NOTE On first launch the sample content is installed into the library. If that does not go through, a Factory Samples notice tells you how many failed and where they were headed. It is retried the next time you launch, so carry on.

2. Load a kit

On launch nothing is loaded. The nameplate reads “KIT — | – empty –” and the pad area says “No drum kit loaded”. Open the browser with the BROWSE button at the top left and double-click a kit (for example 001 LM-400G) to load it.

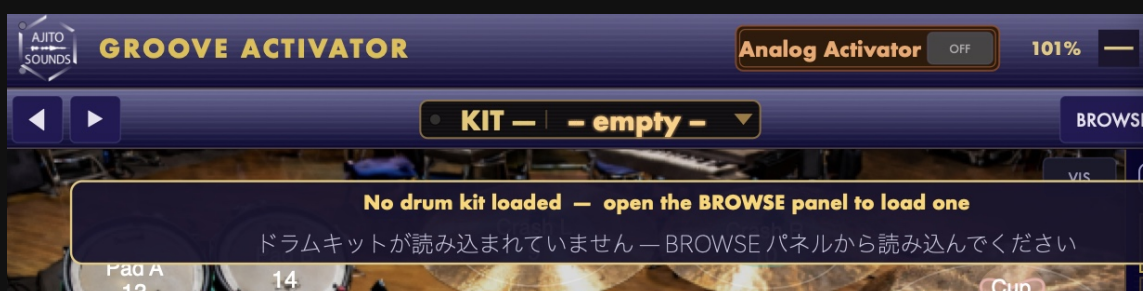


Fig 04-1 Straight after launch — the nameplate reads “KIT — | – empty –”

3. Hit a pad

Click any of the 18 pads at the bottom of the screen, or play C1–B2 (the factory kit’s default mapping) on a connected MIDI keyboard.

4. Adjust in the mixer

In the MIXER tab on the right, balance the channels — Kick / Snare / Hi-Hat / Cymbal and so on.

That’s the basic flow. From here, switch kits and layer the three core modules as you go, and find your own groove.

NOTE If something goes wrong, look in the Help menu. Open User Manual opens this manual, and Contact Support opens an email with the address, the version and your Machine ID already filled in. Common symptoms are collected in Appendix B.

PART III

THE SCREEN

05

INTERFACE OVERVIEW

Interface Overview

The main window is made up of five areas. Once you have a feel for each one’s role, most of your sound-making happens on this single screen. Keep this map in mind first.

The five areas

Area	Role
TopBar (very top)	Global controls: logo, preset name, LOAD/SAVE, UNDO/REDO, Master Volume, Limiter, MIDI LEARN and more.
Pad Section (lower left)	The 18 pads, each showing a waveform thumbnail. Click to select, double-click for the Edit Window.
Edit Window (center)	Detailed editing of the selected pad: waveform, Start/End/Loop, Pitch, Filter, Envelope, Layer, Variation.
Mixer (right)	Channel strips — Volume, Pan, Mute, Solo, Phase, Output Bus — plus the Master section.
Module Tabs (upper right)	Access to Analog / Slice / Instant Activator, Pitch Bend and Hi-Hat.

When the label is not enough

Rest the pointer on a knob or button and wait a moment, and a small box tells you what it does. These arrived in v1.5. You do not have to learn the screen first - point at whatever you are unsure of and it answers.

Simple Mode and Advanced Mode

Switch between them with the MODE switch on the right of the TopBar. Simple Mode shows only the basic parameters so you can make a sound without hunting. Advanced Mode unlocks every parameter for fine detail. Start in Simple, and move up to Advanced when you want more — that’s the order we recommend.



Fig 05-1 The full screen in Simple Mode



Fig 05-2 The full screen in Advanced Mode (all parameters unlocked)

Main TopBar buttons (Advanced Mode)

Button	Function
BROWSE	Opens and closes the browser for kits / presets / pads / layers.
MIDI IN	Toggles external MIDI input on or off (green = on, red = off).
UI SYNC / UI FREE	Switches whether the display follows playback. SYNC selects the pad and layer that sounded; FREE stays locked to your manual selection.
MIDI LEARN	Toggles global MIDI learn mode (see Ch.12).
GRAB	Locks the pad you are editing so it won't change even when other pads sound (see Ch.6).
EDIT	Opens and closes the Edit Window.

NOTE UI SYNC works when MIDI IN is ON. These buttons appear only in Advanced Mode, and can also be toggled from the MIDI menu in the MenuBar.

QUALITY — how many variations are used

QUALITY, at the top of the left panel, decides how many variations the engine draws from. A pad can hold up to eight separate takes, so repeated hits never land on the same recording twice in a row. That is where the human feel comes from.

Mode	Variations used
Eco	One only
Studio	Two, alternating
Master	All eight (default)

Master is the default and the one to stay on. Eco and Studio are there for when many tracks are playing at once and the CPU is struggling. Eco also has a musical use: repeated hits become identical, which is handy when you want a deliberately machine-like feel.

NOTE Using fewer variations does not throw any recordings away. Everything that was loaded stays in memory; only the number played is limited, so the RAM reading does not change.

NOTE Variation buttons beyond the limit are drawn dimmed in the VARIATION row, so you can see that they cannot be selected.

NOTE QUALITY belongs to the plug-in instance rather than the kit, and is saved with the DAW project. Different tracks in the same song can use different settings.

The CPU / RAM / VOX meters

Three meters sit just above QUALITY. They are where you look when something is struggling.

Reading	Meaning
---------	---------

CPU	How busy processing is (%), shading green to amber to red
RAM	How much audio is loaded (MB) — not the total memory the app uses
VOX	Voices sounding right now, with the buffer size and sample rate beside it

NOTE If the sound breaks up, raise the buffer size in your DAW first. If the CPU meter stays red after that, move QUALITY to Studio or Eco.

ROOM (Room Total)

The ROOM knob at the bottom controls the overall amount of room-mic sound for the whole kit; 12 o'clock is the kit's recorded balance (neutral). Turn right and the room comes forward — the whole space breathing with the kit. Push further and it saturates and distorts; that's part of the expression too. Turn left and the room pulls back for a tight, dry sound. The room is the lifeblood of a drum sound, and how far you push it forward becomes the character of the sound.

Panning the drum photo

The drum photo can be panned vertically with a two-finger swipe on the trackpad (or the mouse wheel). Cymbals cut off by the window's aspect ratio are brought into view by a scroll that tracks your fingers 1:1. Double-click any empty part of the photo to snap back to center (except on a pad).

NOTE How far it pans depends on how much of the photo overflows the band. Drag the divider down to enlarge the drum photo and the overflow disappears, so panning does almost nothing. Drag the divider up to shorten the photo and the tops of the cymbals are cropped — that is when panning brings them back.



Fig 05-3 Divider raised so the drum photo is short: the cymbal tops are cropped, and a two-finger vertical swipe brings them into view

Folding sections — open only what you need

Click a section header in the EDIT panel to fold its contents away. ▼ means open, ► means folded. Fold what you are not using and the controls you are working on come within easy reach.

All nine start folded when you open the panel — open only the ones you need. The KITS list in the left panel starts folded too.

Header	Contents
LAYERS & VARIATIONS	Velocity layers L1-L6, variations AUTO and V1-V8, UNDO / REDO DELETE

SAMPLES	The five mic rows C1 / C2 / C3 / OH / Room, with sample names and browse buttons
TUNE & ENVELOPE	TUNE, the envelope graph, ATK / DCY / REL
FILTER & GAIN	LOOP, HP, LP, GAIN, DAMP
MULTI EDIT	Edit several pads at once
REC & SLICE	Waveform, recording, slicing, SENS
PAD FILTER	Per-pad LP / HP with resonance, and the velocity-driven touch wah (Ch.8)
HI-HAT SETTINGS	Hi-hat open/close behaviour (Ch.10)
PAD SETTINGS	POLYPHONY, PAD ROLE, CHOKE, PLAY MODE, REVERSE, PEDAL CC#, DAMP CC#, PITCH BEND

NOTE The KITS (or LAYERS) header in the left panel folds the same way. On the PAD tab the same header switches between category view and number order.



Fig 05-4 All headers folded. Open only what you need and it comes within reach

Seeing the whole mixer — the ⇄ button

Press ⇄ at the far left of the Pad Mixer bar and the side panels are trimmed to the top of the mixer, letting all 18 channels spread across the full width. Every fader is visible without scrolling, which helps when balancing the whole kit. Press it again to go back.

While it is on, two meters appear in the space freed on the left: an L/R stereo scope above, and a stereo pair of analogue VU meters below. The VU shows average level with the same 300 ms needle ballistics as the real thing.

NOTE The kit list folds automatically while ⇄ is on. Turning it off restores the list to whatever state it was in before.



Fig 05-5 With ⇄ on — all 18 channels and Master at a glance, meters on the left



Fig 05-6 The stereo analogue VU meters. The L/R stereo scope appears on the left of the mixer

Help Tags — on-screen descriptions

Hover the mouse over a button or knob and a short description appears — the same idea as Logic's Quick Help. MIDI IN, UI SYNC, GRAB, SET NOTE, ALL LAYER, ALL CH and other controls whose names alone are not enough all carry one.

Once you know your way around, turn them off from View > Show Help Tags. The choice is remembered.

NOTE Help tags are not a substitute for this manual — they say what a control does in a line or two. The details live in the chapters here.

06

PADS

Pads

Each of the 18 pads has a MIDI note assigned to it. The assignments below are the factory state, and the factory kits follow the same layout (only the extension pads Pad B–E are moved to other notes by some kits). Note names follow the plugin's on-screen display (middle C = C3).

MIDI mapping (common to all kits)

NOTE This arrangement is Groove Activator's initial setting. Straight after launch with no kit loaded, straight after INITIALIZE (and Initialize Pad...), and the Default map in the MIDI menu all give you exactly these assignments. They are the same as 001 LM-400G, so switching kits never moves where you hit.

Pad	Name	Note
1	BD (Kick)	C1 (36)
2	Snare Main	D1 (38)

3	Snare Sub	E1 (40)
4	Tom 1	D2 (50)
5	Tom 2	C2 (48)
6	Tom 3	B1 (47)
7	Floor Tom	G1 (43)
8	Hi-Hat	F#1 (42)
9	Crash L	C#2 (49)
10	Crash R	A2 (57)
11	Ride	B2 (59)
12	FX Cymbal	E2 (52)
13	Pad A	A#1 (46)
14	Pad B	A#0 (34)
15	Pad C	G#1 (44)
16	Pad D	C#1 (37)
17	Pad E	A#0 (34)
18	Cup	F2 (53)

NOTE Each pad’s MIDI note can be changed freely (MIDI Note in the Edit Window). The values above are the factory assignment. Pad B–E (Pad 14–17) are extension pads, and some kits move them to other notes.

NOTE The note-naming convention can be switched. Some makers call middle C (note number 60) C3 (the Yamaha convention, Groove Activator’s default), others call it C4 (the Roland convention and many other DAWs) — the same note number therefore appears one octave apart. Choose C3 or C4 under View → “Middle C Is Named” in the menu bar, or click the “MIDI: C1 (36)” text in the Edit Window header. The choice is shared across the whole application and is remembered next time you launch. The note number in parentheses is always the same value regardless of the convention. This setting changes the display only — it never affects the notes that play, or the contents of your kits and projects.

NOTE In most factory kits, Pad B and Pad E share the same note A#0 (34). Combined with CC#1, this is an intentional design for smoothly expressing hi-hat open/close (see Ch.10). The open/close link comes from the pads’ roles (HI-HAT SETTINGS), not from the shared note on its own: with no kit loaded there are no roles yet, so A#0 simply sounds both pads together.

Pad categories

With the PAD button on the left of the Pad Section, you can collapse the pads into six categories (BD / Snare / Toms / Hi-Hat / Cymbals / Etc) to find a pad quickly.

The GRAB button (locking the edited pad)

The GRAB button on the TopBar (Advanced Mode) is a toggle that locks the pad you are editing. When ON, the pad won't switch even if other pads sound during playback or via external MIDI — handy when you want to dial in a single pad while a phrase plays. While GRAB is ON, Shift + click on the drum kit selects multiple pads to edit together in Multi Edit.

NOTE To stop the display following playback altogether, use UI FREE (see Ch.5). UI FREE stops both pad and layer following, whereas GRAB locks only the pad being edited and keeps layer-following active within it.



Fig 06-1 The 18 pads laid out on the drum photo

Returning a pad to its initial state

Right-click a pad and choose Initialize Pad... to return that one pad to its initial state — the default state with no samples in it. Samples, layer count, velocity boundaries, tone, FX, play mode, filter, pitch bend, polyphony, mixer and pad name are all covered. The MIDI note goes back to the factory assignment too (the table in “MIDI mapping (common to all kits)” in this chapter).

INITIALIZE in the left panel returns all 18 pads to their initial state. The MIDI notes go back to the factory assignment as well, so you end up exactly where you were straight after launch. If you were using a MIDI map of your own, pick it again from the MIDI menu.

NOTE To get the contents of a factory kit back, use the restore steps in Ch.17. Initialize Pad... returns a pad to its initial state; it does not bring back that pad's sound from the factory kit.

NOTE Polyphony in the initial state is 16.

What Ctrl+Z brings back

Ctrl+Z restores samples and layer structure, and along with them the pad name, mic input names, the number of variations, the pad FX (filter / gain / CC assignments), pitch bend (on/off and range) and all eight Simple macros (Volume / Attack / Decay / Release / Tune / Pan / Filter / Room). All 16 layers and every velocity boundary are covered.

NOTE Ctrl+Z undoes both adding and deleting a Variation, and Redo (Ctrl+Shift+Z) works too. A deleted Variation comes back with its samples, not just its slot.

The quick-edit popup in Simple Mode

In Simple Mode, clicking a pad on the drum photo opens a quick-edit popup. Its eight knobs — Volume / Attack / Decay / Release / Tune / Pan / Filter / Room — plus Reverse / Reset let you do basic sound shaping without switching to Advanced Mode.

NOTE The Decay knob reads 0–100% (100% at the right = the untouched, full tail; turning left shortens it). In a DAW's generic automation list it may appear as the internal value (a $\times 0.05$ – $\times 4.00$ multiplier).



Fig 06-2 The quick-edit popup opened by clicking a pad (Snare Main)

07

MIXER & OUTPUTS

Mixer & Outputs

The Mixer has two faces: the Mic Mixer, which handles the drum-mic channels of the selected pad, and the Pad Mixer, which works across all 18 pads. Switch between them at any time with the Pad Mixer toggle at the top center.

Mic Mixer (drum-mic channels)

Each channel can be Mono or Stereo (Kick / Snare are usually Mono; Overhead / Room are Stereo). The basic controls are Volume (a Pro Tools-style silver fader), Pan (Width on Stereo channels), Mute / Solo (mutually exclusive), Phase Invert, and Output Bus (Bus 0 = Main, Bus 1–16 = Out 1–16).



Fig 07-1 Mic Mixer — C1 soloed (note the SOLO CLEAR bar at the top)

Sending the ambience out on its own track

The overheads and the room can be sent to their own tracks in your DAW, where you can add reverb to them or squash them with a compressor on their own. The box at the top of each row in the Mic Mixer is where that microphone goes. Choose Out 1 to Out 16 instead of Main and that microphone alone leaves on its own bus.

Put OH on Out 1 and Room on Out 2, for instance, and the close mics stay on Main while the two ambience channels arrive separately in the DAW. It is set per row, so you can just as easily pull out Close 1 on its own.



Fig 07-2 OH sent to Out 1 while the other rows stay on MultiOut

NOTE Make somewhere for it to land first. In Pro Tools create an Aux track and set its input to Out 1. Cubase, Studio One and Ableton Live each have their own way — create the destination tracks first, then assign Groove Activator's rows to Out 1–16.

NOTE A microphone sent to an Out does not pass through the Master Instant Activator. Instant Activator adds about 4 ms of look-ahead to Main only, so mixing something that goes through it with something that does not puts them out of time with each other. If you are sending the ambience out and rebalancing in the DAW, it is safest to switch Instant Activator off (see “Multi-Output Routing” in this chapter).

NOTE Multi Out in the Pad Mixer (one output for a whole pad) is only available while every microphone on that pad is on Main. A pad whose microphones go to different Outs shows "mixed" in grey — the two ways of routing are meant to be used one at a time.

Pad Mixer (18-pad mixer)

Turn the Pad Mixer toggle ON and the mixer switches to one strip per pad — the view for balancing by pad rather than by mic. From top to bottom each strip has Multi Out (per-pad output bus), the pad number, DRIVE / OUT (the per-pad Instant Activator Lite, see Ch.15), M / S, PAN, a Volume fader with dB readout and L/R meter, and the pad name.

Scroll the strips with a two-finger horizontal swipe, or the scroll bar along the bottom. Shift + click selects multiple strips (gold highlight); drag any one of the selected faders and the group moves together, preserving the dB offsets. Double-click the pad name below a strip to rename it (up to 24 characters); the new name is reflected instantly everywhere and saved with the kit.

NOTE Multi Out is enabled only when all of a pad's mics are on Main; a pad routed individually in the Mic Mixer shows a greyed “mixed”. Routing to an Out (1–16) bypasses the Master Instant Activator (see “Multi-Output Routing” in this chapter).

Widen the window and all 18 strips plus Master line up at once, with no scrolling. Which pads sit forward and which sit back can be read from the pattern of fader heights alone. When you are

balancing a whole kit, this is the fastest way to work.



Fig 07-3 Pad Mixer — widen the window and all 18 strips plus Master are visible at once

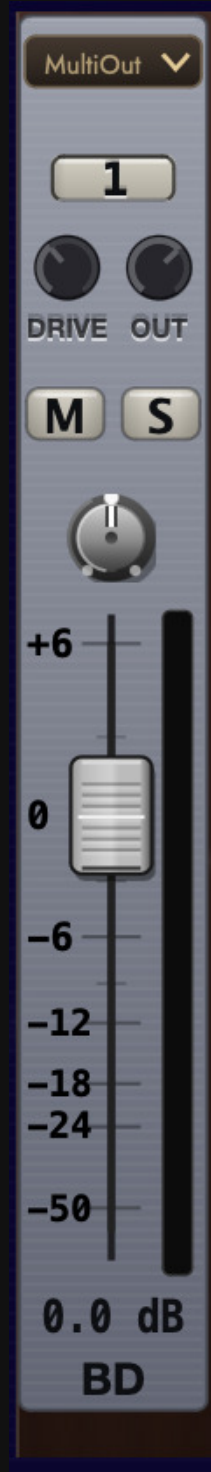


Fig 07-4 Pad strip close-up — PAN below M / S, then the Volume fader

PAN

PAN places that pad's sound left or right. Turn the knob and a sound that is already playing follows it there and then.

To bring it back to centre, double-click the knob, or hold Alt or Ctrl and click it.

NOTE PAN acts on the sample layer. The AA layer plays at centre (see Ch.13).

NOTE The same PAN is also on the Simple Mode popup, bottom right (see Ch.6).

Master section

Master Volume, Master Mute and Master Limiter. The Master strip is always shown at the right edge in both views.

Console brightness — matching the mixer face to your eyes

The face of the mixer, the background the strips are drawn on, can be set to any brightness you like. Choose Console brightness... from the View menu and a small slider appears beside the mixer. Drag it and the console changes as you go.

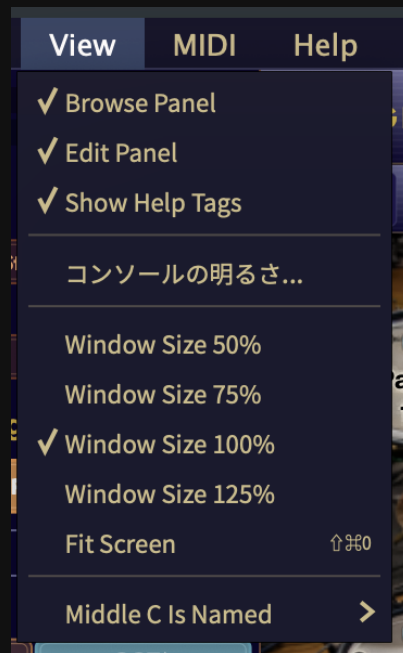


Fig. 7-6 Console brightness... in the View menu

Left is a darker console, right a lighter one. Labels, scale marks and engraving follow the face automatically, so everything stays legible wherever you leave it.



Fig. 7-7 The slider appears beside the mixer; the console changes as you drag.

NOTE Reset to default returns it to the shipping brightness at any time. All the way to the right gives you the look you had before.

NOTE This affects the mixer face only; no other part of the interface changes. The setting is remembered on this PC and is not stored per project - it is there to match your screen and your room, not your song.

Multi-Output Routing

Groove Activator supports 17 bus outputs (Bus 0 = Main + Bus 1–16 = Out 1–16), so you can send kick or snare to their own tracks and process them individually in the DAW.

CAUTION Routing to an Out (1–16) bypasses the Master Instant Activator. The Instant Activator adds look-ahead latency (about 4 ms) to the Main output only, which would flange against the zero-latency Out buses — so it is disabled deliberately to keep everything phase-aligned. Keep a pad on Main if you want the master saturation / limiter to act on it.

VST3 (Ableton Live, Cubase, Studio One and others)

Set your DAW up for multiple outputs, then insert Groove Activator. In VST3, enabling the output buses on the DAW side makes Out 1–16 appear as destinations. The steps differ from DAW to DAW.

CAUTION Whether Out 16 is usable depends on your DAW. If you run out of destination tracks, add more on the DAW side.

Pro Tools

Load the AAX version as a Multi-Mono / Multi-Channel Instrument and route each bus to any Bus in Pro Tools.

PART IV SHAPING THE SOUND

08

THE EDIT PANEL

The EDIT Panel

In the Edit Window you can edit the selected pad's sample at the waveform level — trimming, pitch and texture, shaping a single hit with care.

Waveform parameters

Start Point / End Point are the playback start and end positions. Drag the handles on the waveform display, or enter values numerically. With Loop ON, playback continues from the Loop Point when it reaches the End Point.

Pitch, filter and envelope

Pitch (Tune) is ± 24 semitones. Filter is a two-stage Low-Pass + High-Pass (cutoff adjustment). The envelope has four knobs — ATK / DCY / SUS / REL (ADSR) — with defaults of ATK 0 ms, DCY 100%, SUS 0%, REL 50 ms.

SUSTAIN — holding partway through the decay

SUS sets the level the sound falls *to*. At 0% it falls to silence (exactly as in v1.3 and earlier). Raise it and the sound stops partway and holds there. The four dots in the graph are draggable; the SUS dot moves vertically.

Knob	Range	What it does
ATK	0-2000 ms	Fade-in time
DCY	0-100 %	Where in the sample the fall begins (100% = no cut)
SUS	0-100 %	Level held after the fall (0% = down to silence)
REL	0-2000 ms	Time the fall takes



Fig 08-2 Top: SUS 0% (same sound as v1.3 and earlier). Bottom: SUS 51% — a shelf appears at the level it falls to

NOTE SUS defaults to 0%. At 0% the sound is exactly as before — older kits and projects play unchanged.

NOTE On GATE pads, releasing the key ignores SUS and falls to zero. SUS has no effect on pads set to infinite LOOP: with no natural end and no note-off, holding a level would leave the voice sounding forever.

NOTE The SIMPLE face's ATTACK multiplies this ATK (1.0x = unchanged, 0x = attack removed). DECAY and RELEASE work the same way. Kits and projects saved in v1.3 or earlier may hold 0x for that multiplier; it is read back as 1.0x automatically.

NOTE From v1.5, tuning a pad up no longer folds high frequencies back into the audible range as tones that were never in the sample. The higher you tune, the more this matters. At Tune 0 nothing is processed at all — you hear exactly what was recorded.

NOTE All parameters in the waveform tab act only on the selected Pad / Layer / Mic. ALL LAYER / ALL CH are not applied (see “Broadcast editing (ALL LAYER / ALL CH)” in this chapter).

The WRITE: readout — where your edit lands

Just under the Variation strip in the EDIT panel, at the right-hand edge, is a WRITE: readout. It tells you where the knob you are about to turn will be written.

For example, WRITE: L1 · V1 means "layer 1, variation 1 only", and WRITE: ALL L · ALL V means "every layer and every variation". With several pads selected it is prefixed MULTI-PAD, and with all of them, ALL PADS.

NOTE When the edit goes to more than one place, the WRITE: readout is given a background. Glance at it before you move a knob.

There are two Tunes

Around this screen there are two things called Tune, and they are different. The TUNE slider on this panel sets the pitch of the layer and variation you have selected. The Tune macro (on the Simple Mode popup, and in DAW automation) sets the pitch of the whole pad.

The two add together. Moving one does not change the other's readout, so when the pitch moves further than you expected, look at both.

NOTE The Slice Activator has a TUNE of its own. That one acts on the whole loaded loop and is separate from these two (see Ch.14).

Input Select (choosing and renaming the source)

Each drum-mic channel's Input Select shows the name of its assigned input source. Pick an audio input and its device / channel name appears, so you can see at a glance which mic feeds which input. Double-click an Input Select label to rename it freely; the name is saved with the kit.



Fig 08-1 Edit Window (sample editing panel)



Fig 08-2 Input Select / file list (double-click a label to rename)



Fig 08-3 Audio device input settings

Velocity Layers

You can place multiple samples on a single pad, switched by velocity — a firm hit gives a sound with a solid core, a soft one something delicate. This switching is what gives a drum sound its realism.

Adding and removing layers

Add a new layer (L1–LN) with the [+] button in the Velocity section of the Edit Window; you can currently create from L1 up to L8. Remove with [-] (a confirmation dialog appears). A deleted layer can be restored with Ctrl+Z, and the same applies to deleting a Variation.

NOTE Each layer tab shows the velocity range that layer covers.

LAYER X-FADE — smoothing the joins between layers

When velocity moves from one layer to the next, the timbre changes in a step. Turn LAYER X-FADE on in the left panel and the two layers are blended either side of the boundary, so they run into one another. It tells on playing that uses fine dynamics, the way an acoustic kit does.

The number beside it is how wide the blend is, counted in velocity steps, from 0 to 32. The default is 6. Wider is smoother, but more of the time two layers sound at once, so more voices are used. Narrowing it costs nothing.

NOTE It is off to begin with; with it off, layers switch cleanly at the boundary as before. The setting is remembered per plugin instance (per project in a DAW).

NOTE At 0 nothing blends even when it is on — it sounds the same as off.

Broadcast editing (ALL LAYER / ALL CH)

You can choose whether an edit affects only the selected layer/channel or the whole pad at once. The ALL LAYER / ALL CH toggles at the top right of the Edit Window switch the write scope four ways. With both OFF, only the selected layer and channel are affected; ALL LAYER ON reaches every layer in the pad; ALL CH ON reaches every channel in the layer; both ON reaches all layers and channels. Combine it with a Variation's AUTO to write to all Variations at the same time (see “AUTO mode” in this chapter).

When an edit reaches more than one cell, the knob does not set them all to the same value — it moves them all by the same amount, so whatever balance you built between layers survives. On a pad where L1 is -1.1 dB, L2 is +2.0 dB and the rest are 0.0 dB, raising GAIN by 3 dB gives +1.9 dB, +5.0 dB and +3.0 dB. The 3.1 dB gap stays a 3.1 dB gap. Eight parameters work this way: TUNE, ATK, DCY, REL, HP, LP, LOOP and GAIN.

NOTE As soon as any one of them reaches its upper (or lower) limit, the whole move stops there. The knob stops with it, so the number you see is always a value something really holds — one cell never sticks at the limit while the others keep going and the spread quietly shrinks.

Where your edit will be written is shown at all times in the WRITE indicator at the top of the Edit Window (e.g. WRITE: ALL L · ALL V). It prevents an unintended mass overwrite. Edits that involve a broadcast can be undone and redone with the UNDO DELETE / REDO DELETE buttons — even a change spanning several layers/channels is reverted as a single step (also the alternative when your DAW takes Ctrl+Z first).



Fig 08-4 Velocity Layer tabs with the ALL LAYER / ALL CH / AUTO / WRITE display



Fig 08-5 Pad and mixer interlock — with PAD 2 selected, the mixer and Edit follow

Variations

A feature that switches between multiple sounds — randomly or in order — within the same velocity range. Even at the same strength, each hit changes slightly, so programmed drums start to breathe like a live performance.

Adding and removing V1–VN

Switch between V1, V2, V3... with the Variation Tab Bar at the top of the Edit Window. Add with [+], remove with [-]. A removal can be undone with Ctrl+Z.

AUTO mode

Turn on the AUTO button (orange accent) and the variation switches automatically on every note-on — Round Robin switches in order, Random switches randomly. Combining AUTO with the layer ALL LAYER / ALL CH toggles lets you write an edit across all Variations at once (see “Broadcast editing (ALL LAYER / ALL CH)” in this chapter).

Phase Scope

The Variation section also includes a Phase Scope (oscilloscope). Double-click to open or close it and check the phase on the spot.

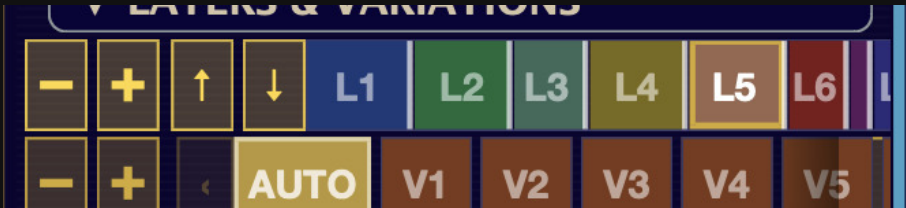


Fig 08-6 Variation Tab Bar (switching V1–VN)

PAD FILTER — per-pad filtering and touch wah

PAD FILTER in the EDIT panel acts on everything that pad plays. Where FILTER & GAIN above it is a plain per-layer HP/LP, this one is per pad and adds resonance (Q) plus a touch wah whose cutoff follows how hard you hit.

The ON/OFF button to the right of the header switches the whole section. It ships OFF on every pad. When it is OFF the audio is left untouched. Even with it ON, leaving LP at 20000 Hz, HP at 21 Hz and both VEL amounts at 0.00 changes nothing.

Control	What it does	Default
LP	Removes everything above this frequency (low pass)	20000 Hz
HP	Removes everything below this frequency (high pass)	21 Hz
LP Q	Resonance — lift around the LP cutoff	0.71
HP Q	Resonance — lift around the HP cutoff	0.71

LP VEL	How much velocity moves the LP cutoff (-1.00 to +1.00)	0.00
HP VEL	How much velocity moves the HP cutoff (-1.00 to +1.00)	0.00

NOTE Alt-click (or double-click) any control to return it to its default. The LP and HP scales are logarithmic — fine control down low, broad strokes up high.

Touch wah — the tone opens as you hit harder

Raise LP VEL and soft hits keep the cutoff closed while hard hits open it quickly, the way a wah pedal opens under your foot. Playing with dynamics alone now moves the tone. The higher LP Q, the more the opening sings.

HP VEL works the other way: the harder you hit, the more bottom is removed, giving a tighter sound. Combine the two and only your hardest hits pull towards the midrange.

NOTE Negative values invert the response — hit harder and the filter closes instead.

The response graph

The graph above the controls shows the filter shape you have set. Horizontal is frequency (marked at 100 Hz, 1k and 10k), vertical is gain. With either VEL amount away from zero, a dim line shows the shape at full velocity and a bright line shows the shape at the velocity you last played, with that velocity printed at the top right.

NOTE The graph follows the note you just played, so you can watch the wah track your playing while you hit the pad.

09

PAD SETTINGS

Pad Settings

PAD SETTINGS

The PAD SETTINGS at the bottom of the same panel decide how the selected pad sounds. Typical values for a hi-hat pad are POLYPHONY 32, PAD ROLE HH CLOSE for the closed hat and HH OPEN for the open hat, PLAY MODE ONE SHOT, REVERSE OFF, PEDAL CC# CC1, PEDAL INVERT OFF. PAD ROLE tells the pad which side of the hi-hat it is; leave every non-hi-hat pad on NORMAL. Turn PEDAL INVERT ON and pressing moves toward open instead — for pedals with reversed polarity or if you prefer the inverted feel.

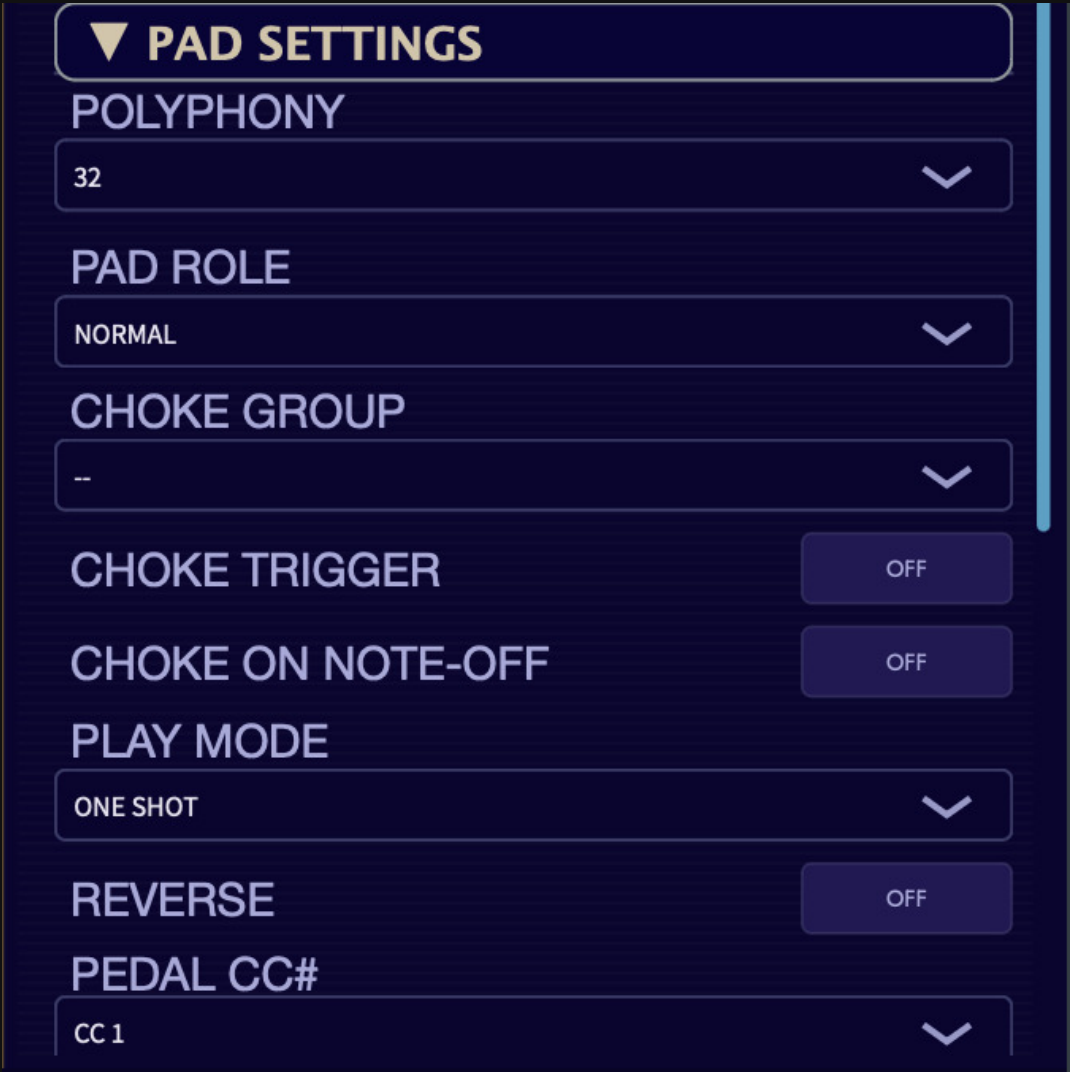


Fig 09-1 PAD SETTINGS — everything about how this pad behaves, from POLYPHONY down to PITCH BEND

CHOKE GROUP — grab a cymbal to stop it

This recreates what a drummer does by hand: hit a crash, then grab it to cut it short. Give pads a number (1–8) in CHOKE GROUP and pads sharing that number become a group that can stop each other. No number (--) is the default, and nothing happens.

Within a group there are two kinds of pad. CHOKE TRIGGER OFF means the pad can be stopped; ON means the pad does the stopping. When a stopping pad sounds, the pads in its group that can be stopped go quiet. Stopping pads never cut each other.

Setting	Meaning
CHOKE GROUP	-- (default) / 1–8
CHOKE TRIGGER	OFF = can be stopped (default) / ON = does the stopping
CHOKE ON NOTE-OFF	OFF (default) / ON = stops itself when the key is released

In a DAW — CHOKE ON NOTE-OFF

This is the simplest way to use it. Turn CHOKE ON NOTE-OFF ON for a crash pad and the sound stops the moment its note ends. The length of the note becomes the length of the cymbal, so you can draw exactly where the grab happens. No group setting is needed.

NOTE The default is OFF. With it ON the sound stops as soon as you release the key, so turn it on only for the pads that need it.

Grabbing from a pad or an e-drum kit

You can also keep one pad as the grab. Set the crash to CHOKE GROUP 2 with CHOKE TRIGGER OFF, and the grab pad to CHOKE GROUP 2 with CHOKE TRIGGER ON. Hitting the grab pad stops the crash.

Separate numbers let you choose what stops. Put crash left on 2, crash right on 3 and the ride on 4, and grabbing the left one leaves the right one and the ride ringing — just like a real kit.

NOTE If a group has no partner pad, CHOKE GROUP is drawn dimmed, so you can see on screen that nothing will be stopped.

How this relates to the hi-hat

The hi-hat choke is one case of the same rule. In the factory kits the hi-hat pads are placed in group 1 automatically when the kit loads, with the closing pad set to CHOKE TRIGGER ON. They behave exactly as before, so there is nothing to set up for the hi-hat.

NOTE CHOKE GROUP, CHOKE TRIGGER and CHOKE ON NOTE-OFF are saved with the kit. INITIALIZE returns them to –, OFF and OFF.

Supported controllers

Works with MIDI expression pedals in general (Roland EV-5, M-Audio EX-P, YAMAHA FC7, Moog EP-3 and others). Since a MIDI keyboard's modulation wheel also sends CC#1, you can use the wheel in place of a pedal.

Setup steps

First connect the pedal to your MIDI interface and configure it to send CC#1 (calibrate beforehand if it has a polarity switch). Next confirm CC#1 is received, for example in your DAW's MIDI monitor. Finally, insert Groove Activator on an instrument track — pressing the pedal closes the hi-hat, releasing it opens it back up.

Performance tips — foot expression

Press the pedal and no chick sounds — that's where people first stumble. The pedal decides not whether a sound plays but how long the ringing hat lasts and how it closes. The foot-close chick itself is played on the closed-hat pad. From there the foot motion maps straight to the sound: press down while an open hat rings and the tail snaps shut (a choke); hold the pedal shallow while striking for a tightened, loose-hat ring (half-open); vary the openness between strikes and each hit rings for a different length; hit the closed-hat pad as you press down and the chick lands with the real foot timing.

Hear it in the bundled demo

Inside the download folder there is a Demo folder holding a performance example that uses this CC#1 hi-hat open/close control, as a Standard MIDI File (.mid). Note that the installer does not place it anywhere; open it straight from the download folder. Rather than step-entered, the open/close is expressed by skillfully moving CC#1, so it is a good reference for the nuance of real hi-hat technique.

PITCH BEND

A module that brings dynamic pitch expression to your drums using the MIDI pitch-bend wheel. Dropping the tail of a tom, adding a waver to a snare roll, making a kick undulate like a sub-bass — expressions hard to get from acoustic drums, at your fingertips.

Settings (per pad)

Open PAD SETTINGS in the EDIT panel and use PITCH BEND at the bottom to enable or disable pitch bend per pad. RANGE is ± 1 to ± 24 semitones (default ± 12). Only pads with bend enabled respond to the wheel, so to bend only the toms, turn ON just the tom pads — the rest are unaffected.

Examples in performance

Add a downward or upward bend at the end of a tom fill and it speaks like a talking drum. A subtle bend during a snare roll adds a human feel. A shallow bend on the kick makes it undulate like a sub-bass. Easing a cymbal upward during a legato gives an '80s gated-style effect.

NOTE The larger the Range, the more the tone breaks up. Outside of extreme effect use, ± 2 to ± 12 is recommended.

NOTE Hold the wheel up and the next hit sounds at that pitch. The wheel position is remembered, so hits do not fall back to the original pitch.

10

HI-HAT

Hi-Hat

A dedicated set of parameters for continuously controlling hi-hat open/close with a modulation wheel or expression pedal (MIDI CC#1). The more you press the pedal (raise CC#1) the more it closes; release it and it opens — just like a real hi-hat pedal.

HI-HAT SETTINGS

Fine-tuning controls for how the pedal responds. Every factory kit ships already dialled in, so just plug in a pedal and play; come back here when you feel like tailoring the response to your own pedal and style. The standard values used during recording are below.

Parameter	Standard
CLOSE THRESHOLD	100
MAX DECAY / MIN DECAY	2.00 / 0.05
FADE SPEED	0.30
OPEN MAX / CLOSE MIN	40 / 100

How it works: the pedal position (CC#1) continuously sets how long the open hat rings. OPEN MAX / CLOSE MIN frame the ring-length map — at or below OPEN MAX is the longest ring, at or above CLOSE MIN the shortest, continuous in between. MAX DECAY / MIN DECAY are the longest and shortest ring in seconds. CLOSE THRESHOLD is the point where pressing down chokes the ringing open hat. FADE SPEED is how fast that choke closes — left (SLOW) closes naturally, right (FAST) mutes instantly. 0.30 is standard; I personally lean toward SLOW, closer to the tail of a real hi-hat.

NOTE With the pedal fully released (at or below OPEN MAX) the open hat rings for the whole sample - it is no longer cut at MAX DECAY when the sample is longer (v1.5 and later; before, even a released pedal cut it at MAX DECAY). MAX DECAY is the length at the start of the pedal travel; if the sample is longer, the ring shortens from the sample's own length.

Seeing the pedal value (v1.5 and later)

Select a pad whose PAD ROLE is HH OPEN or HH CLOSE and a line such as "PEDAL CC1 0 OPEN" appears in the EDIT panel just below the HI-HAT SETTINGS header. It follows every CC#1 that arrives from a wheel or from the DAW, and turns orange with CLOSED once the value passes OPEN MAX.

NOTE If the open hat suddenly sounds short - a mere "chick" - look here first. CLOSED means the wheel is still up, or the DAW part carries a CC#1 event. The pedal remembers the last value it received, so once closed it stays closed until the next CC#1.

The RESET button on the right returns it to the released position (0) without touching anything already ringing. Reset All Controllers (CC#121), which many DAWs send on stop, does the same.

Nothing resets it automatically on kit load, and what you do with your own pedal while the DAW is stopped is left alone - that would feel like the hat opening by itself to anyone holding a real pedal down. Only the pedal movement that came from the DAW's playback is returned to its value from before playback, when playback stops or a loop jumps back to its start (v1.5.1).



Fig. 10-1 The PEDAL line under HI-HAT SETTINGS. CC#1 is at 127, so it reads CLOSED in orange, with RESET on the right

11

HAND DAMPING

DAMP — Hand Damping

DAMP makes an open, ringing pad sound as though you had put a hand on it — turning a long “toooooone” into a short “ton” or “tok”, continuously, with one knob.

Where it is

On the pad image, directly above each pad, there is a small knob. It appears the same way on both the SIMPLE and the ADVANCED page.

NOTE Every one of the 18 pads has one — the drums (bass drum, snares, toms, floor tom), the cymbals (hi-hat, crash L / R, ride, FX cymbal, cup) and Pads A–E.

Using it

Action	What happens
Drag up	More damping
Drag down	More open
Hold Ctrl and drag	Four times finer
Alt-click or double-click	Back to 0 (fully open)
Shift-click	Select several pads

With several pads selected by Shift-clicking, a drag moves all of them by the same amount — handy for tightening a whole kit at once. To start a new selection, click a pad that is not selected, or press Esc.

NOTE At 0 nothing is applied at all. You hear the recording exactly as it was captured.

What it actually does

It measures the recording itself, finds the low resonance that particular pad has, and pushes it down. The attack — the first 8 milliseconds — is left alone, because a pad muted by hand still keeps the brightness of the moment the stick lands.

NOTE The amount of damping is the same whether you hit hard or soft. Making it velocity-dependent was tried during development; even damping sounded more natural.

NOTE It follows TUNE. Change the pitch and the frequency being pushed down moves with it.

Damping while you play — DAMP CC#

Instead of dragging the knob by hand, you can drive the damping from a MIDI controller. Raise the modulation wheel and the sound that is ringing tightens up right there. Hit first, then damp — the same motion a drummer makes with their hand, straight into the instrument.

You will find it at the bottom of PAD SETTINGS, in the EDIT panel on the ADVANCED page, called DAMP CC#. Select the pad you want to damp, then switch it ON.

Control	What it does
DAMP CC#	Which CC drives it (1–127). Default is CC#2
ON / OFF	Whether this pad follows the wheel. Default is OFF
Damping: <name>	Shows which pad is currently selected

CAUTION Only one pad can be damped at a time. Switching another pad ON moves it there. Damping all 18 at once was tried — raising the wheel simply made the whole kit disappear, which is unplayable. You only damp one pad at a time with your hand too, so this turned out to be the natural choice.

NOTE To damp several pads together, Shift-click their knobs on the SIMPLE page and drag. That way takes as many as you like.

CAUTION CC#1 is deliberately not the default. Most factory kits use CC#1 for the hi-hat pedal, so setting DAMP CC# to CC#1 would close the hi-hat every time you move the wheel. If you pick the same number the display warns you with ⚠. To use the modulation wheel anyway, change the hi-hat's PEDAL CC# to CC#4 first.

NOTE It affects both the sound that is ringing and the next one you hit. Hold the wheel up and the next hit comes out already damped.

NOTE Changes are smoothed over 25 milliseconds, so moving the wheel quickly produces no clicks.

NOTE The wheel bites early. A small move already damps the pad, and it deepens gently from there. All the way up sounds the same as setting the knob to 100.

Worth knowing

CAUTION Damping shortens the sound. Because the length changes, raising it in the middle of a piece you have already written will change how long the tails ring.

NOTE The DAMP setting is saved with both the kit and the project, so you can share a kit with the pads already damped.

NOTE The DAMP CC# setting (number and on/off) is saved with the kit and the project too.

12

MIDI LEARN & MAPS

MIDI Learn & Maps

You can assign Mixer / Sample / Pad knobs and faders (Volume, Pan, Master Volume, Tune, Filter, Envelope and so on) to an external MIDI controller. There are two ways to do it.

Method A: Global learn mode

Press the “MIDI LEARN” button on the TopBar to enter learn mode (it glows gold when ON). Left-click the knob or fader you want to assign and it enters a waiting-to-learn state with a flashing yellow frame; move your external controller and that CC is linked automatically. Left-click another parameter to keep mapping several in a row. Press “MIDI LEARN” again to leave learn mode.

Method B: Right-click menu

You can also assign individually without learn mode. Right-click the knob or fader, choose “MIDI LEARN” from the menu, then move the controller to link it. To clear it, right-click again and choose “MIDI Unlearn”.

What cannot be assigned

PAN is not in the CC-learn list. It can, however, be automated from your DAW (see Ch.7).

Several instances at once

Put several instances in the same project and each keeps its own CC assignments. Opening and closing the editors changes nothing.

MIDI maps

The MIDI notes across the pads can be saved and recalled separately from the kit. Save Current Notes as MIDI Map... in the MIDI menu names and stores the current arrangement. Saved maps appear under MIDI Map in the same menu. Use kit's own notes (no map) puts the kit's own notes back.

NOTE Tick Keep MIDI Map when loading kits and your map stays in place as kits are loaded — useful for pinning the layout to your own pads or e-drums.

NOTE Saved maps go into the MidiMaps folder in the library (see Ch.3).

The MIDI monitor

The MIDI MONITOR in the left panel lists incoming MIDI as type, note, number, velocity and channel. When nothing sounds, it tells you whether anything is arriving at all.

NOTE When a lot arrives at once, a line reading -- N events lost (too fast to log) -- appears. Only the display fell behind; nothing was dropped from the performance.

NOTE If too much MIDI arrives while SET NOTE is learning, Too fast - press SET NOTE and hit the pad again. appears. That learn does not take — press SET NOTE and hit the pad again.

NOTE The “MIDI LEARN” button on the Slice Activator’s ActionBar learns each slice’s trigger note and is separate from the general-parameter MIDI LEARN described here.

PART V

THE FOUR ACTIVATORS

13 ANALOG ACTIVATOR

Analog Activator

A 14-section module that recreates the character of vintage analog drum machines as an engine that responds to your knobs every time it sounds. Get thickness and presence you can’t obtain from samples, shaped freely across 14 sections.

Out of deep respect for those legendary machines, I rebuilt it from scratch with my own hands. — Gota

NOTE The small ON / OFF at the top right of the panel decides whether the Analog Activator is heard. While it is OFF the knobs are dimmed and cannot be moved — so you never turn one and wonder why nothing changed. Switch it ON and they come to life.

The 14-section layout

From top to bottom of the panel, the following 14 sections are laid out (each is collapsible; by default BASS DRUM is open).

No.	Section	Description
01	BASS DRUM	Analog kick (MORPH between Ground and Aggressive)
02	SNARE DRUM	Analog snare (variable SNAPPY)
03	HI-HAT	Metallic hat (Closed / Open switch)
04	RIMSHOT	Hard, dry rimshot
05	CLAP	Layered hand clap
06	COWBELL	Metallic cowbell
07–10	TOM / FLOOR	High / mid / low toms and floor tom
11–14	SWEEP 1–4	Noise sweep / FX



Fig 13-1 Analog Activator (BASS DRUM expanded)

Controls per section

Each section is based on TUNE / TONE / DECAY / ATTACK / PAN / LEVEL, with independent knobs for shaping the sound. Section-specific knobs include SNAPPY on the SNARE DRUM, ACCENT on the BASS DRUM, and SWEEP / NOISE / PUNCH on the SWEEP sections. Each section also lets you set OUT CH, MIDI note, Mute / Solo and HP / LP filter individually. HI-HAT accepts two MIDI notes, Closed (CL) and Open (OH).

NOTE Each section's OFS (offset) delays that section so its attack lines up with the sampled sound. Running Initialize (New Kit in the File menu, or INITIALIZE in the side panel) returns every OFS to 0 ms. The tone knobs are kept as before.

NOISE and PUNCH on the SWEEP sections

NOISE blends a pitch-tracking noise layer into the sweep — the '80s electronic-drum-style body. PUNCH shapes the attack of that noise layer: the hard thump of the first hit. Since PUNCH sculpts the noise attack, use it together with NOISE. With NOISE at 0 it has no effect and the knob greys out. Bring up NOISE first, then set the impact with PUNCH.

About MORPH (BASS DRUM)

The MORPH slider at the top of the BASS DRUM continuously blends two characters: “Ground” (a thick kick with a solid core) and “Aggressive” (a punchy kick).

Bundled preset: “Analog Dream”

As an example of the Analog Activator’s sound, we bundle the factory preset “Analog Dream”. It showcases sound design across the 14 analog sections, is added to your library automatically on first launch, and can be selected from the Analog preset menu.

14 SLICE ACTIVATOR

Slice Activator

A sampler that slices a loop is nothing unusual — cut, lay the slices on pads, play. Most stop there. The Slice Activator’s biggest feature is that you can send a slice straight to a drum-mic channel with Ctrl+C / Ctrl+V, building a multi-mic kit out of loop material in an instant. This is the backbone of Groove Activator — a flow found in no other drum instrument.

Workflow

First, drag and drop an audio file onto the Slice Activator tab (WAV / AIFF / MP3 / M4A / AAC / CAF / FLAC supported). Beyond files from the File Explorer, you can drag an audio region straight from your DAW’s arrange area. Next, set the range you want to use (START / END), tell the plugin how fast the loop is with BARS and the meter, and choose how to cut it with CUT. Fine detail is added or removed by hand on the waveform. Finally, copy the selected slice with Ctrl+C and paste it onto the corresponding drum-mic channel with Ctrl+V — instantly deploying slices from a loop onto Mixer channels such as Kick / Snare / Hi-Hat.

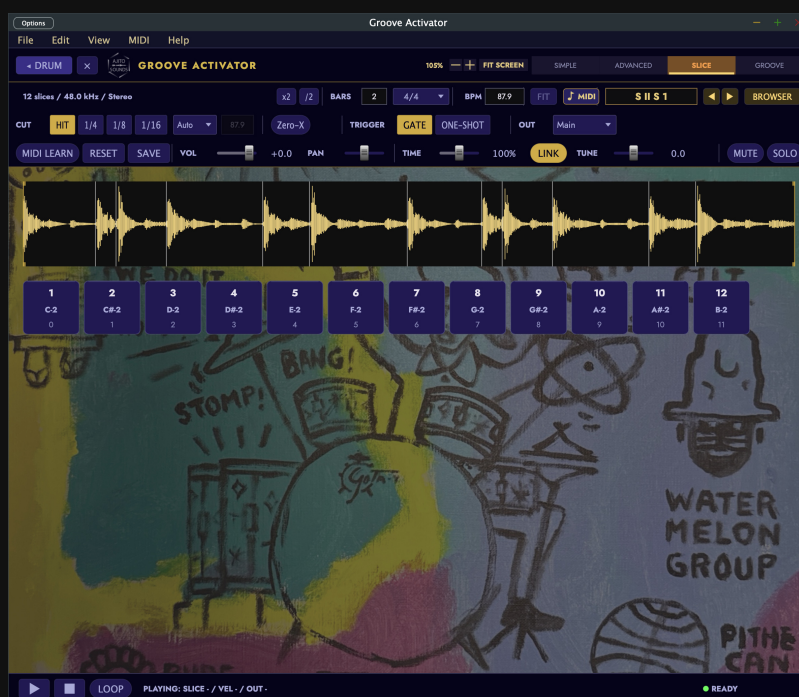


Fig 14-1 Slice Activator with material loaded (12 slices / 98.3 BPM)



Fig 14-2 The waveform — the vertical lines are the slice points; drag either end for START / END

Speed and pitch — TIME and TUNE

The TUNE slider in the bottom bar shifts the entire loaded loop by up to ± 12 semitones. Next to it, TIME changes the speed between 50% and 200%. With LINK on, speed and pitch move together, the way a tape machine behaves. Switch LINK off and you can change one without the other — pitch alone, or speed alone.

Pasting a slice into a channel carries the current Tune across to the pad.

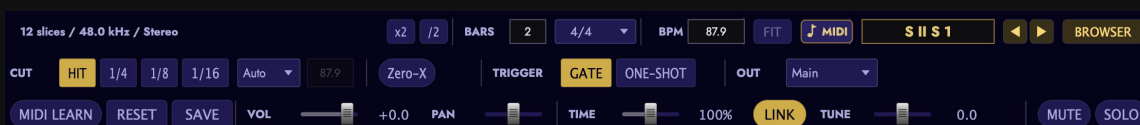


Fig 14-3 The three rows above the waveform — top: BARS, meter, BPM, FIT / middle: CUT, grid speed, Zero-X / bottom: VOL, PAN, TIME, LINK, TUNE

NOTE With LINK on, moving either TIME or TUNE updates the other readout.

NOTE With LINK off, the conversion is built when you release the slider and takes effect from the next sound. Nothing changes while you are still dragging. Triggering a slice and playing the range with ► both use the same setting.

Paste Undo and flash linking

A paste onto a channel can be undone with Ctrl+Z. Also, hitting a slice pad flashes the corresponding slice in the waveform, and clicking a slice in the waveform flashes the corresponding pad — so the mapping is always visible, in both directions.

Adding and removing slices

Double-click an empty part of the waveform and one slice is added at that point. A single click on a marker removes that slice. Double-clicking on a marker does nothing.

NOTE The slice count is always shown in the header above the waveform.

How many slices

Automatic slicing creates up to 64 slices. Adding them by hand has no such limit — you can keep adding as long as there is room between neighbouring slices. How many you can trigger is set by the number of MIDI notes: there are 128 notes, so up to 128 slices can be assigned and played.

Tiles are laid out twelve to a row. At 64 slices the sixth row (61-64) reaches the bottom edge of the window: the numbers show, but the note name, index and OUT lines beneath them are hidden. Only the display is cut — the slices are all there, and they play over MIDI. The count is shown at the left end above the waveform, as 12 slices (Fig. 14-3).

Set the tempo with bars and meter

Type how many bars the loop contains into BARS in the header. Choose the meter next to it (4/4, 3/4, 5/4, 6/8, 7/8 and so on) and the BPM is calculated and shown straight away. You tell the plugin the tempo rather than asking it to guess. If what you thought was one bar turns out to be two, press x2: BARS doubles and so does the BPM. /2 does the opposite, and is greyed out when the bar count is odd.

NOTE Because the BPM is calculated from BARS and the meter, the three can never disagree.

Choose the part you want to use

Drag the left and right edges of the waveform to set the range used as the loop (START and END). Everything outside the range is dimmed. On material with silence at the tail, trimming here makes the BPM come out right and keeps the exported MIDI in place. FIT expands the range to fill the view.

Checking the range by ear — LOOP

 (play),  (stop) and LOOP (repeat on or off) sit at the bottom left of the screen. They play the START-to-END range you set, so you can hear whether the range is right before you slice.  lights green while sound is playing.

NOTE With LOOP off it plays once and stops. Same position, same buttons as the GROOVE page.

Comparing presets by ear

Open BROWSER and click a name: about two seconds of that preset's audio plays. Click down the list to compare them without loading anything.

NOTE Auditioning is not loading. The loop you have open, the slice points you made by hand and your settings are all left alone. To load one, press LOAD or double-click the name.

NOTE Ctrl + scroll zooms, scroll alone moves sideways, and Ctrl + double-click returns to the original size.

Choose how to cut — CUT

The four CUT buttons decide how the loop is cut. HIT keeps the hits where they were played, so the human feel survives. 1/4, 1/8 and 1/16 divide the loop on that note grid. The loop is re-cut the moment you press. Going back to HIT restores the arrangement you had just before switching to a grid, so anything you fixed by hand is not lost.

The speed of the grid is chosen next to CUT. Auto uses the BPM taken from the material; Fix uses a tempo you decide, typed into the field on the right. From one performance you can produce three different MIDI feels — as played, locked to the grid, or deliberately pushed — with a single button.

NOTE On material with no BPM the 1/4, 1/8 and 1/16 buttons are greyed out. Enter BARS and the meter first.

Line up the cuts — Zero-X

With Zero-X on, slices you add and markers you move stick to the nearest zero crossing in the waveform. This avoids the click that a cut in the middle of a wave produces.

Setting trigger notes

Double-click a slice tile to choose the MIDI note that plays it. Default returns it to the note its position implies. Clear ALL note assignments drops every assignment at once.

Presets

The state of the Slice Activator saves as a .gdaslicepreset. Slice positions, trigger notes, each slice's OUT / MUTE / SOLO, and the CCs bound to VOL and PAN are all kept with it.

NOTE How the audio is remembered depends on where it lives. Audio in the library's SlicerLoops folder is remembered by its place inside the library — a library moved with Back Up Everything in the File menu still opens it. Audio kept outside SlicerLoops is remembered by its location on that machine (see Ch.3).

Export the groove as MIDI

You can export the arrangement of detected slices (the groove) as a MIDI clip. Drag the MIDI drag handle in the FileInfoBar onto a DAW track and it creates a clip with each slice's trigger note laid out at the original timing and BPM — reconstruct the loop's rhythm in your DAW, or play it back through another instrument. Each slice's note number can be changed by double-clicking the slice tile below the waveform.

NOTE The default file name for the export is the slicer preset name plus the BPM (for example SR 2 76.0bpm.mid).

NOTE Slice trigger notes can also be learned with the “MIDI LEARN” button on the ActionBar (per-slice MIDI LEARN; see Ch.12).

15

INSTANT ACTIVATOR

Instant Activator

The Instant Activator comes in two stages: the Master Instant Activator on the master output, and the per-pad Pad IA Lite. Both add analog-style saturation — loudness and harmonics — with zero latency.

Master Instant Activator

It consists of Input Gain (before the Master, ± 24 dB), Output Gain (final output, ± 24 dB), and a look-ahead brick-wall limiter to prevent clipping. When ON, the “Instant Activator” header on the Master strip lights up along with the Input (cyan) / Output (lime) / Limiter (amber) knobs, so you can see at a glance that it is engaged.

NOTE The Instant Activator (INPUT + LIMITER) is OFF (bypassed) at startup. Turn it ON manually if you want it always engaged.

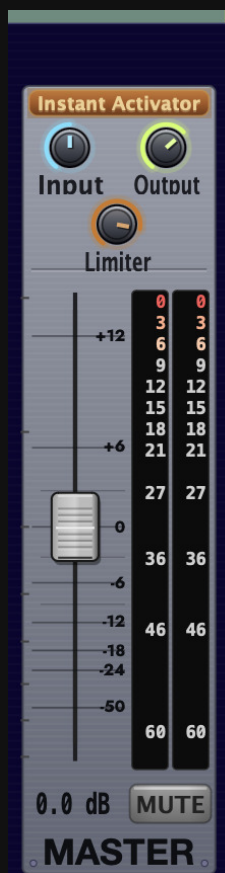


Fig 15-1 Master Instant Activator (ON — knobs lit)

Pad IA Lite (per pad)

The two DRIVE / OUT knobs at the top of each Pad Mixer strip are the per-pad Instant Activator Lite — analog-style saturation plus clipping, per pad. Fatten just the kick, push just the snare forward. Click the “DRIVE” label (or the knob) to toggle; while ON, DRIVE lights orange and OUT lights gold. DRIVE sets 0 to +24 dB of drive, OUT trims -24 to +6 dB; the basic move is to bring the gained level back down with OUT. Values are kept when OFF, so you can A/B with one click. No look-ahead is used, so latency is zero and OFF pads are completely untouched in the signal path.



Fig 15-2 Pad IA Lite — pad 2 ON (DRIVE orange / OUT gold)

16

GROOVE PLAYER

Groove Player

GROOVE plays a MIDI file (.mid) directly inside Groove Activator, so you can hear how a groove sounds on the kit you have loaded before you bring it into your DAW.

NOTE There is no new audio path. What you hear from ► travels exactly the same route as MIDI from your keyboard or your DAW — layers, variations, choke, hi-hat, the MIDI monitor and UI SYNC all behave as usual.

NOTE Control changes written in the .mid pass through as well, not just the notes. A groove whose hi-hat pedal was recorded as CC opens and closes exactly as it does in your DAW.

Where the files live

Put your .mid files in the Grooves folder in the library. FOLDER opens that location in the File Explorer, creating it if it is not there yet. You can also drag files onto this page straight from the File Explorer.

NOTE If you have moved the library (Ch.19), Grooves moves with it.

Reading the list

Column	What it shows
NAME	The file name
BPM	The tempo written in the file
METER	The time signature
BARS	Length in bars, decided by the last note ON (see below)
HITS	The number of note-ons
SECTION / STYLE / FEEL	Labels you add yourself (next section)
KIT	The kit that goes with this groove (next section)
★	A three-step mark (see below)

The grooves that come with it

Groove Activator ships with grooves played by Gota Yashiki. Intro, Verse, Chorus and Fill are all there, so you can build the shape of a song just by putting them in order. How many there are, how fast they run and which styles they cover is shown in the BPM / STYLE / SECTION columns of the list itself.

This is not a closed box. New grooves arrive with future updates: the ones you have not touched are refreshed, while the stars and labels you set are kept.

Their labels (SECTION / STYLE / FEEL) and the kit each one goes with are already filled in. Some have the hi-hat pedal written as control change (Verse w ccHat, Verse w ccFill), so playing them reproduces the pedal work as well.

- NOTE

You can relabel or star the supplied grooves like any other. What you change is kept on your side and is never overwritten by an update; the ones you have not touched are refreshed when we improve them.
- NOTE

The files themselves live in the Grooves folder and are ordinary .mid files — rename them, drag them into your DAW, or delete them as you like (deleted ones can be retrieved from .UndoCache).

KIT — the kit that goes with a groove

Right-click a row and choose KIT to record which kit belongs with that groove. The kit you pick appears in the KIT column, and the same menu then offers "LOAD KIT nnn" to load it. Once you have more than a hundred grooves, remembering which kit each was made for stops being possible — so record it while you still know.

- NOTE

Only the kit's name is recorded, and never into the .mid itself (like labels and stars, it lives in a small companion file alongside). A groove you have not told anything about simply leaves the KIT column empty — nothing is guessed.

Labels — SECTION / STYLE / FEEL

Right-click a row to label it on three axes. You can then filter the list by those labels.

Axis	Choices
SECTION	Intro / Verse / Chorus / Bridge / Vamp / Fill / Break / Solo / Ending
STYLE	Rock / Funk / Jazz / Latin / R&B; / Hip Hop / Pop / Blues / Metal / Reggae / Country / Electronic / Dance / Afro / Bossa
FEEL	Straight / Shuffle / Tight / Loose / Half-time / Double-time

- NOTE

Labels are never written into the .mid. They are kept separately in the Tags folder in the library, so your files are not altered by a single byte and still open anywhere else.

Controls

Button	What it does
▶ / ■	Play / stop. Double-clicking a row also plays it
LOOP	Repeat on or off
LOAD KIT nnn	Load the kit this groove was made with
♪ DRAG	Drag the selected .mid to your DAW or the File Explorer
DELETE	Remove the selected groove from the list (the Delete or Backspace key does the same)
UNDO / REDO	Put it back, or remove it again (Ctrl+Z / Ctrl+Shift+Z)
FOLDER	Open the Grooves folder in the File Explorer
RELOAD	Re-read the folder

- NOTE** DELETE only moves the file into Grooves/UndoCache/, so you can also retrieve it from the File Explorer. Emptying that folder is up to you — Groove Activator never clears it.
- NOTE** Drag a row up or down to put the list in whatever order you like. That order is kept the next time you open it. To go back, right-click a row and choose "Sort by name". Reordering is off while a filter or search is active — with only part of the list visible, there is no honest answer for where the hidden rows should go.
- NOTE** Press and hold inside the BPM, METER, SECTION, STYLE, FEEL or KIT cell to get that column's menu directly. The full row menu is still there on right-click.

Stars — three levels (v1.5 and later)

A star column sits at the left of the list. Each click cycles it: one star, two, three, then none. Once you have a hundred grooves, names alone stop being enough — this is a way to mark what you liked as you listen.

The filter above the list offers 1+, 2+ and 3 stars, showing only rows at or above that level.

SECTION		STYLE		FEEL		★		METER		FOLDERS		SEARCH...	
NAME				★	BPM	METER	BARS	HITS	SECTION		STYLE	FEEL	KIT
Reggae 02 Intro Fill				★★★★	70.00	4/4	1	15			Reggae		
Funky 01 Chorus(Ride) w Fill				★★★★	98.00	4/4	2	39	Chorus		Funk	Straight	LM-400G
MEMO : 16分ハット主体。BPM 90〜100 向き。フィルなし。ハットは少し後ろ。													

Fig. 16-3 The star filter and star column above; the memo for the selected row below.

- NOTE** Stars are never written into the .mid. They live in a small companion file beside it, so a .mid you drag into your DAW is exactly the original.

Writing a memo (v1.5 and later)

Right-click a row and choose Write memo... to leave a short note on that groove. When the row is selected the note appears under the list, after a gold MEMO .:

It is meant for one line to your future self — which song you used it in, that it sits better a few BPM slower, and so on.

NOTE Memos live beside the .mid like stars do. Clearing the text removes the companion file.

Remembering the current scene (v1.5 and later)

Right-click and choose Remember current scene to tie the kit, Slice preset and Analog preset you are hearing right now to that groove.

Once tied, the LOAD KIT button becomes LOAD SCENE. Pressing it brings back the Slice and Analog settings along with the kit, so a groove and the sound you built around it come back together.



Fig. 16-5 The KIT column: the GOTA shelf sits right under (none), above MY KITS (v1.5 and later). LOAD KIT loads shelf kits too



Fig. 16-4 The menu you get by right-clicking a row

NOTE Only the chosen names are remembered, not the settings themselves. Rebuild a kit later and, as long as the name matches, the new one is what loads.

About LOAD KIT

This is available only when the kit a groove was made with matches a kit on this PC exactly. It will not guess at a similar name: loading the wrong kit would be worse than doing nothing.

NOTE Loading a kit stops playback, so nothing keeps sounding while pointing at samples that are no longer there.

About 🎵 DRAG

The original .mid stays where it is; a copy is handed over. You can drop it on a DAW track or into a File Explorer folder.

It does not sync to your DAW

GROOVE runs on its own inside Groove Activator. It does not follow your DAW's playhead or tempo. It is a page for listening. When you want a groove in the song, hand it over with 🎵 DRAG.

How BARS is decided

The bar count comes from the last note ON. Note-offs are not counted.

NOTE Counting note-offs would add a whole bar of silence to a loop whenever the last release crosses the bar line by even a fraction. One real loop released 0.021 of a beat — 13 milliseconds — past the line.

NOTE Note-offs that fall past the end are folded back inside the loop. Without that, the release would arrive just after the loop wraps and cut the first hit of the next pass.

What gets saved

Your DAW project stores only the name of the groove you had selected. Whether it was playing is deliberately not saved: a project that starts making noise the moment you open it is an accident, not a restore.

NOTE It stores the name, not the file's location. Open the project on another PC and the groove is found as long as a .mid of the same name is in that PC's Grooves folder.

PART VI

WORKING WITH KITS

17

FACTORY KITS & PRESETS

Factory Kits & Presets

A Kit is the unit that saves a complete state — pad assignments, Layers, Variations, Mixer settings, the state of the Analog / Slice Activator, and even MIDI LEARN. Save one and you can recall that whole sound at once.

Bundled factory kits (10 in all)

After installation, the following 10 kits are ready from the BROWSE panel: 001 LM-400G, 002 Muted Beat, 003 Deep Kit, 004 BreakThrough, 005 Dig This, 006 Dope, 007 Analog Fun (Analog Activator only, no samples needed), 008 House of Love, 009 Real Black, 010 Basic Kit.

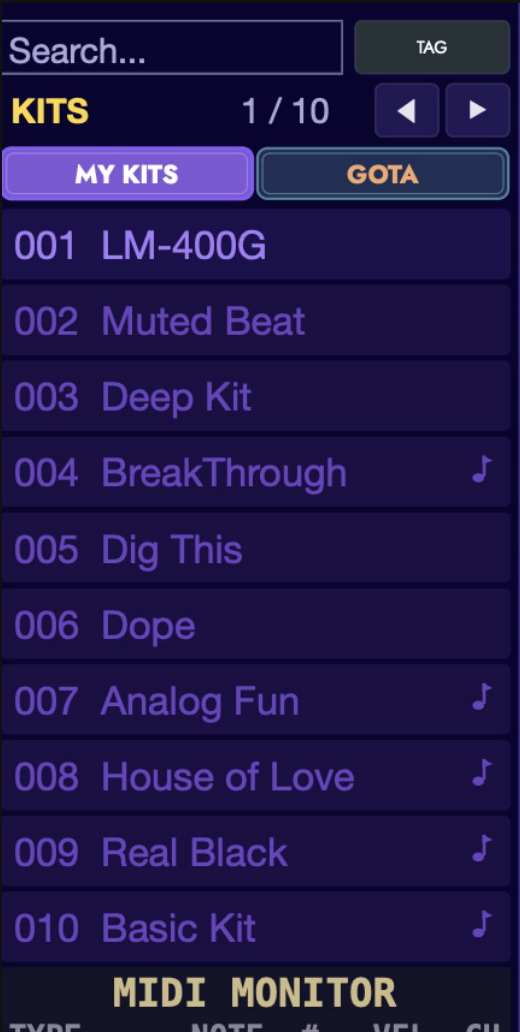


Fig 17-1 The kit list in the BROWSE panel

The GOTA shelf — a read-only kit collection (v1.5 and later)

NOTE From v1.5 the shelf also holds 011 Super Tight - kit 001 with the Simply Tight snare, hats, rim and tambourine on top. The PAD tab has the same shelf switch (MY PADS / GOTA); the GOTA shelf holds the four Simply Tight pads (Closed Hat, Open Hat, Rim, Snare Red) and three tambourines (Tamb Small, Tamb, Tamb Double).

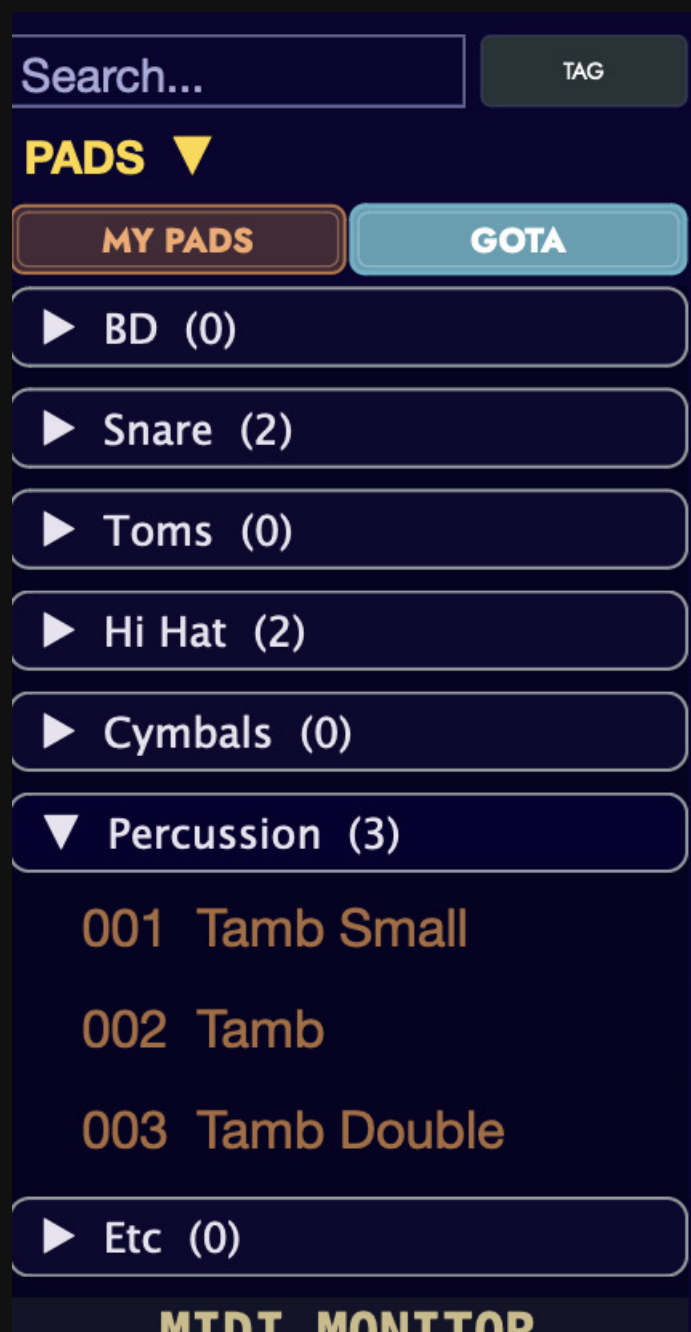


Fig. 17-2b Shelves on the PAD tab: MY PADS (orange) and GOTA (pale blue); the GOTA shelf holds the three tambourines under Percussion

At the top of the KITS list in the BROWSE panel you will find buttons that switch between kit collections. MY KITS on the left is your own; the GOTA shelf sits next to it. The GOTA shelf is a read-only collection curated by AJITO SOUNDS, and it grows with each update.

Switching shelves also changes the colour of the list: violet for MY KITS, pale blue for the GOTA shelf. You can tell which one you are looking at without reading a single kit name.

	MY KITS	GOTA shelf
Load	Yes	Yes
Save	Yes	No
Numbering	001-100 (yours)	001-100 (per shelf)
On update	Untouched	Replaced

NOTE Load a kit from the GOTA shelf, press KIT SAVE, and it always saves into MY KITS. Nothing is ever written back to a shelf. Whichever shelf you read from, what you make stays in your own.

NOTE Numbering is per shelf. GOTA 001 and MY KITS 001 are different kits.



Fig. 17-2 MY KITS (violet) on the left, the GOTA shelf (pale blue) on the right. The colour of the list tells you where you are.

Kits that bring a Slice with them

Some kits carry a loop (a Slice) alongside their drum sounds. In the browser list those kits have a small musical note after their name. Loading one also loads that loop into Slice Activator.



Fig 17-2 The note after the name marks a kit that brings a Slice with it

If you are working in Slice and load a kit that carries a different loop, the plugin asks first. Choose “Keep my Slice” and only the drum kit is swapped — the Slice you are working on stays. Choose “Replace” and the kit's loop takes over.

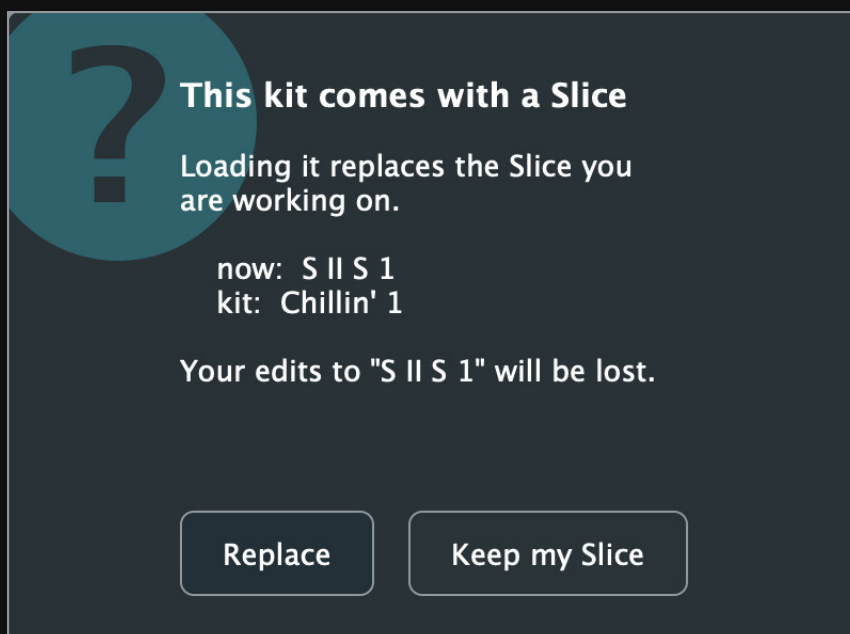


Fig 17-3 The question asked before the Slice you are working on is replaced

NOTE The question only appears when you have edited the Slice you are working on. If you only loaded it and changed nothing, the swap happens silently.

NOTE Switching kits by MIDI Program Change never asks, so nothing interrupts you while you play.

Bundled presets

Alongside the kits, ready-to-play presets are included (SR 1 / SR 2, Chillin' 1 / 2, S II S 1, Groove Ride 1 / 2 / 3).

Keeping the factory kits safe

If you try to overwrite one of the factory kits 001-010, a different warning appears. Its title is FACTORY KIT - Overwrite? and the button that goes ahead is Overwrite Factory Kit. Overwriting an ordinary slot only asks Overwrite Kit?.

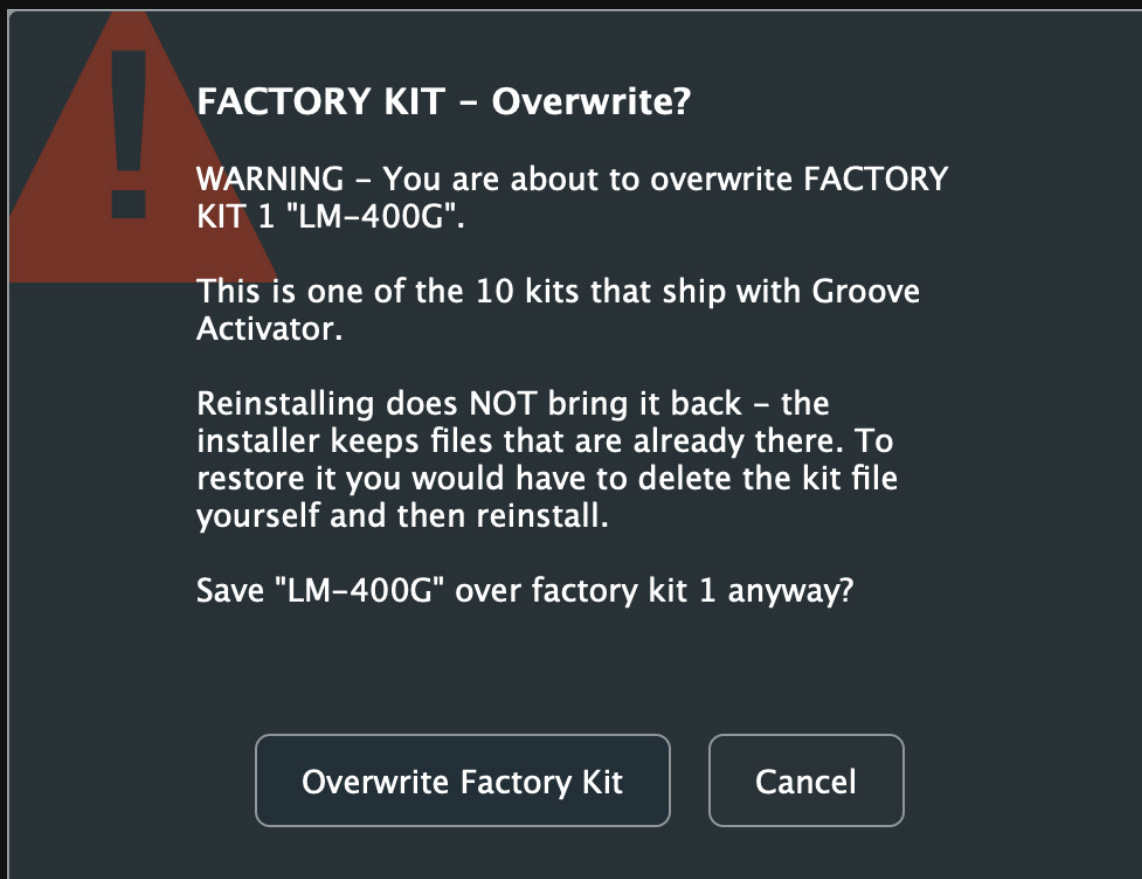


Fig 17-4 Factory kit overwrite warning

CAUTION A factory kit you have overwritten does not come back when you reinstall. The installer keeps files that are already there.

From v1.5 you can restore it from the GOTA shelf. Kits 001-010 sit there in their factory state and can never be overwritten. Load one, press KIT SAVE, and it lands on whichever slot of your own shelf you choose.

NOTE If you would rather not use the shelf, the old route still works: delete that file from the Kits/ folder and run the installer again.

Clearing a pad

Right-click a pad and you can choose between two ways to clear it. Clear Variation 1 on All Layers (Keep V2+) clears only Variation 1 on every layer; V2 and above remain, so the pad still plays. To empty the pad completely, choose Initialize Pad... Clear Variation 1 can be undone with Ctrl+Z, but only for samples that came from a file — a sample that was recorded or pasted and never saved to a file cannot be brought back.

NOTE Initialize Pad... returns that pad to its factory state: samples, layer count, velocity boundaries, tone, FX, play mode, filter, pitch bend, polyphony, mixer and pad name. The MIDI note goes back to the factory assignment too (the table in Ch.6).

About the factory kit refresh in v1.5

In v1.5 the velocity layers of factory kits 001-010 were evened out, so playing softer or harder tracks your touch more closely. The samples themselves are unchanged - not one byte - only the level balance inside each kit.

NOTE Songs you have already made are unaffected: a saved project restores its own settings and never re-reads the kit file.

Your previous kits are kept, not deleted. On update they move to Kits/_superseded_selfheal_<date>/ together with a note explaining how to bring them back (the EXPLORER button in the BROWSE panel opens that folder). Factory kits you edited yourself are never touched, because their contents differ.

To go back to the previous feel, import one of the superseded .gdakit files from that folder with the IMPORT button. It lands in a free slot, so nothing is overwritten and you can compare old and new side by side.

18

SHARING KITS

Sharing Kits

Exporting (Kit / Pad / Layer packs)

Export from the File menu writes a kit, a pad or a layer out as a pack. The default name in the save dialog is the kit name for a Kit, and "kit name + pad name" for a Pad or a Layer (for example LM-400G BD, or LM-400G BD L1 for a layer). The name recorded inside the pack is the same, so renaming the file never puts it at odds with the name inside.

NOTE If the kit has not been saved yet, the default name is just the pad name. The default name carries no extension: type over the name and the extension stays intact.



Export Kit Pack (Share Full Kit)

商業 Kit として配布するためのメタデータを入力してください (optional)
Enter metadata that ships with this Kit (Shopify-ready). All fields optional.

Creator / 制作者

Collaborator / コラボ相手 (optional)

Song / 楽曲名 (optional)

Year / 年 (e.g. 2026)

Description / 説明 (optional)

Samples / 音源

Include samples — works anywhere (large) / 音源も入れる (どこでも開ける… ▼

Save... Cancel

Fig 18-1 Kit Pack export dialog

The .gdapack format

Kit files use the .gdapack extension — a ZIP-based container. From v1.5 you choose whether the sample audio goes inside (the default is to include it, so the pack opens anywhere). It contains all Drum Engine pad + Mic settings, the full state of all 14 Analog Activator sections, Slice Activator state, Master / Pitch Bend / Hi-Hat / Instant Activator settings, and Metadata (author, description, tags, thumbnail). From the File menu you can save the current kit and export/import a Kit Pack.

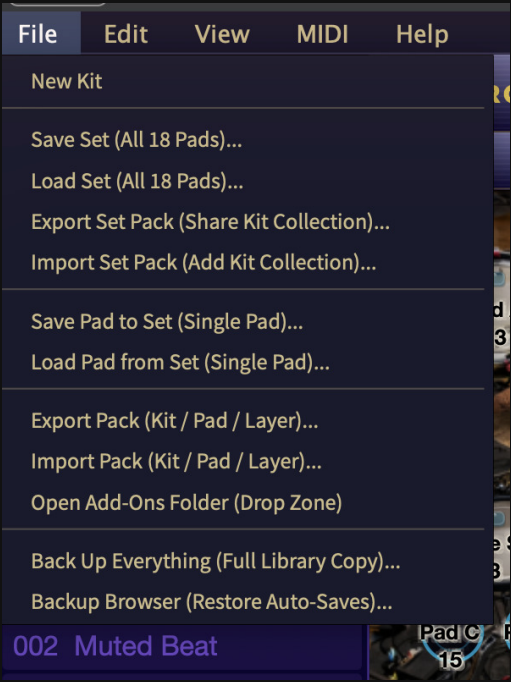


Fig 18-2 File menu

Exporting without the samples (v1.5)

The window that opens when you press EXPORT has a "Samples" field. Choose whether the audio goes inside the pack.

Choice	Size (KIT 001)	Good for
Include samples (default)	475 MB	Opens on any machine. Same as before.
Settings only	49.8 KB	Someone who already has the same sounds. Small enough to email.

A "settings only" pack carries no audio. It plays by referring to sounds of the same name in the receiving library. A kit built from the factory sounds therefore opens for anyone, but a kit that uses sounds you recorded yourself will not play unless the other person has them too.

- NOTE** Missing audio never fails silently: on import you are told "the pack did not contain them - ask the sender for a complete .gdapack".
- NOTE** A Slice loop is always bundled, whichever choice you make - a loop cannot be reproduced by reference alone.

Importing a pack

Import from the File menu brings a pack in. For pad and layer packs the file-chooser title shows where it is going (for example Import Pad Pack -> Pad 1 (BD)). An imported pad is also kept in the library under Pads/, and its name is updated. The MIDI note of the destination pad is kept -- if the pack carries a different note, the pad still plays on the note it had.

.gdapadpack and .gdalayerpack can also be dropped straight onto a pad. Dropping a wav onto a pad loads it as a sample.

NOTE Audio inside a pack can be .wav, .aif or .aiff.

MY KIT - keeping your own version (v1.5)

Once you have shaped a factory kit to taste, press KIT SAVE and store it in a free slot. The factory kit stays where it is, and you can keep as many of your own versions as you like (there are 100 slots; everything outside 001-010 is yours).

From v1.5 a saved kit remembers which kit it came from. The list shows that origin beside the name, and typing the original name into the search box brings the factory kit and your versions together.

```
001 LM-400G
014 LM-400G Even
016 My Tight Setup  <- LM-400G
```

"My Tight Setup" does not contain "LM-400G" in its name, yet it is found by origin - so you do not have to be careful about naming.

NOTE The origin keeps pointing at the original factory kit however many generations you branch, so nothing gets lost along the way.

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ORGANISING THE LIBRARY

Organising the Library

Organising with tags

The TAG button above the list filters kits, pads and layers by tag (kits and layers from v1.5).

Right-click a row, choose TAGS..., then pick an existing tag or make one with "New tag...". Picking a tag that is already on toggles it off.

Use your own words - "live", "that song", anything. There is no limit on how many tags you create. Choosing one from the TAG button leaves only the entries carrying it.

NOTE Pads may also pick up a tag from their name ("LM-400G Cup" becomes LM-400G). Names with no such cue get none. A tag you added by hand is never removed by an automatic one.

Recalling from the library

Drag straight from the PADS list in the BROWSE panel onto a pad to recall it. Right-clicking the list and choosing LOAD works as well.

Adding your own audio (Add-Ons)

Put additional audio in the Add-Ons folder. Open Add-Ons Folder (Drop Zone) in the File menu opens that location in the File Explorer.

Moving your library somewhere else

You can change where kits, pads and audio are kept. Use it to gather everything on an external drive, or to free up space on the internal one. SET LOCATION, under the BROWSE panel, opens a folder chooser. EXPLORER simply reveals the folder in use.

Once you pick a folder you are asked what to do. Copy my library there writes the current library to the new place and then switches to it. If the folder already holds a Groove Activator library you are offered Use what is there instead — nothing is copied and that folder is used as it stands.

Choice	What happens
Copy my library there	Write the library to the new place, then switch
Just point there	Copy nothing and use the folder as it stands
Cancel	Nothing changes

- NOTE** Copying never deletes anything from the old place. Check that everything works in the new location, then tidy up the old one yourself. If a folder of the same name already exists at the destination it is left untouched rather than overwritten.
- NOTE** Slice Activator and Analog Activator presets and the Slice loops move too (the two folders described in Ch.3). The manual and the MIDI maps are placed by the installer and stay where they are.
- NOTE** After changing the location, quit Groove Activator and open it again so every panel picks up the new place.

About saving your edits (important)

After editing a kit, always SAVE (Ctrl+S) to store it into the current kit. Only on SAVE are your edits written to the kit file. If you load another kit or start a new kit (INIT) without saving, unsaved edits are lost. Always SAVE before switching kits.

- NOTE** You cannot save while a kit is loading. If Kit is still loading. Try saving again in a moment. appears, wait a moment and press SAVE again.
- CAUTION** The auto-saved snapshots in the Backup Browser are a safety net and are NOT restored automatically on launch. To keep your edits reliably, you must SAVE.

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RECORDING & BOUNCING

Recording & Bouncing

Record a real drum and it goes straight onto a pad. Recording in Groove Activator takes the inputs of your audio interface into a pad's mic channels directly. Put a mic up, hit the drum, and that pad becomes your sound.

Setting up to record

Open REC & SLICE in the EDIT panel. For each mic row, pick the audio input to use with Input Select. Kick mic on Close, overheads on OH, and so on — every row can take a different input.

Recording

Press ● REC to start and press it again to stop. What you record goes into the pad and layer you have selected, ready to hit straight away.

NOTE The file goes into Samples/ in the library, named pad name_mic name_timestamp.wav (see Ch.3). Save the kit and that sound becomes part of it.

Recording format — why there is nothing to choose

There is no sample-rate selector. In a DAW the rate follows the DAW; running on its own it follows the audio device. A plug-in receives whatever the host hands it, so recording at a different rate is simply not possible. What you are running at is shown on the VOX line in the left panel, like "512 / 48kHz".

There is no bit-depth selector either. Recording is always 32-bit float. That format has no ceiling, so material that goes past 0 dBFS is not clipped on the way in — pull it down afterwards and it comes back. If you work in 32-bit float in Logic, nothing changes for you here.

Setting	What happens
Sample rate	Follows the DAW / audio device automatically
Bit depth	32-bit float (fixed)
Longest take	120 seconds
Files written	One mono WAV per mic channel

NOTE A kit remembers the rate it was made at. Open a 96 kHz kit in a 48 kHz session and the pitch and length stay right — whatever conversion is needed happens for you.

NOTE While recording is available, room for a 120-second take is set aside. It grows with the rate: about 154 MB at 48 kHz and about 308 MB at 96 kHz. That space is reserved whether or not you record, and it is not part of the RAM figure in the left panel (that shows how much audio is loaded).

Waiting for the hit (ARMED)

With auto-trigger on, pressing ● REC puts it into ARMED and recording starts the moment sound arrives. With only sticks in your hands, you do not have to reach for the transport.

NOTE How loud that has to be is set by the slider beside it, from -60 dB to 0 dB (-40 dB by default). While auto-trigger is off the slider is dimmed.

Take after take (multi-take)

With multi-take on, each finished take moves on to the next layer. Layers run from the softest velocity upwards, so record your softest take first and work up. If you run out of layers, more are added for you.

NOTE With auto-trigger and multi-take both on, it re-arms after every take. Just hit progressively harder and the velocity layers build themselves.

Bouncing in a DAW

Use your DAW's Bounce function as usual to export the Master output. After setting up Multi-Output (see Ch.7), bounce each Aux channel individually to export stems such as Kick / Snare / Hi-Hat separately.

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BACKUP & RECOVERY

Backup & Recovery

As insurance against PC migration, OS reinstall or accidental overwrites, regular backups are recommended. Where your data lives is set out in Ch.3.

Backing up everything

Choose Back Up Everything (Full Library Copy)... from the File menu and pick a destination. Your library and your settings are copied into a single folder there. Press it, choose where, and that is all.

The folder you get also contains MANIFEST.txt (hash and size of every file inside) and README.txt (how to put it back). To restore, follow README.txt and put the folders back where they came from.

NOTE The license is not included. To use the plugin on another PC, activate it with the serial number from your purchase (see Ch.3). The manual and the auto-saved snapshots are not included either.

Self-contained Pack formats (recommended for distribution/reuse)

Internally, Groove Activator can generate and load self-contained ZIP Packs along five axes. Because they contain no absolute paths and embed the samples, the sound won't disappear even when carried to another PC.

Format	Contents
.gdapack	Whole kit (all Pads / Layers / Variations + samples)
.gdapadpack	Single Pad (1 Pad + related Layers / Variations + samples)
.gdalayerpack	Single Layer (1 Layer + samples)
.gdasetpack	Whole Set (Slicer state + all samples)
.slicerpack	Single Slicer (loop + slice info)

NOTE Pack formats are also ideal as a self-contained backup for distribution and reuse. Export your favorite kits and you can load them straight back after a PC migration or OS reinstall.

Going back to an auto-save

If you accidentally overwrite a kit, reach past auto-saved snapshots from File menu -> Backup Browser and restore from there.

NOTE If a sample in a Set cannot be found, it is re-resolved from the file name on load.

Restoring (moving to a new PC)

On the old PC, use File → Export Pack (or Export Set Pack for the whole Set including the Slicer). On the new PC, choose File → Import Pack and it is expanded and registered under Kits/ automatically. Because DAW projects reference kits by name, a project loads as-is once a kit of the same name is visible; sample paths resolve inside the Pack.

NOTE If you keep kits in a cloud-sync folder such as OneDrive, the files can become “online only” and unreadable. When syncing between PCs, copy them back to local storage first. Packs (.gdapack and friends) are ZIPs, so they are unaffected.

APPENDIX

A

KEYBOARD SHORTCUTS

Keyboard Shortcuts

Groove Activator provides keyboard shortcuts for frequent operations. To avoid key-binding conflicts with the plugin host, some operations are accessible only via the MenuBar.

Global

Key	Action
Ctrl + Z / Ctrl + Shift + Z	Undo (all controls) / Redo
Ctrl + S / Ctrl + O	Save the current kit / Open a kit
Ctrl + N	New kit (INIT)
Space	Audition the selected pad

Window size (zooming the UI)

Key	Action
Ctrl + - / Ctrl + +	Shrink / enlarge the UI by 5%
Ctrl + 0	Reset the UI to 100%
Shift + Ctrl + 0	Fit Screen

You can also pick 50 / 75 / 100 / 125% and Fit Screen from the View menu. These work in both the standalone application and the DAW (VST3 / AAX).

Across the top of the window sits “101% – + FIT SCREEN”: the number is the current zoom, – and + step it by 5%, and FIT SCREEN sizes the window to the largest that fits your display. It is in the same place on SIMPLE, ADVANCED, SLICE and GROOVE.

There is a gold handle at the bottom-right of the window. Drag it to resize the window directly. It works the same in Standalone and in a DAW.

NOTE

The window keeps its aspect ratio, so dragging the handle scales it proportionally. Some DAWs do not let you drag the plug-in window frame itself — even then the corner handle, the – / + buttons, FIT SCREEN, Ctrl + - / Ctrl + +, and the View menu all still work. Whichever way you change it, you end up at the same size.

NOTE

The size you choose is remembered: the window reopens at the same size next time (per project in a DAW). If the stored size would not fit the screen, it opens reduced until it does.

Slice Activator

Key	Action
Ctrl + C / Ctrl + V	Copy the selected slice / Paste to a Drum Mic Channel
Delete	Delete the selected slice
↑ / ↓	Switch slice selection

Accessed from the MenuBar (no key binding)

The following are accessed from the MenuBar inside the window; no key bindings are assigned on purpose, to avoid conflicts with your DAW. File → Save/Load Set, Export/Import Set Pack, Save/Load Pad, Export/Import Pack, Backup Browser. Edit → Copy Layer/Pad, Paste, Add/Remove Layer, Normalize. View → Browse/Edit Panel. MIDI → MIDI Input / UI Sync.

CAUTION

Some DAWs take Ctrl+Z before Groove Activator sees it. Groove Activator also provides UNDO DELETE in the right-click menu, so please use the UI menu for Undo in those hosts.

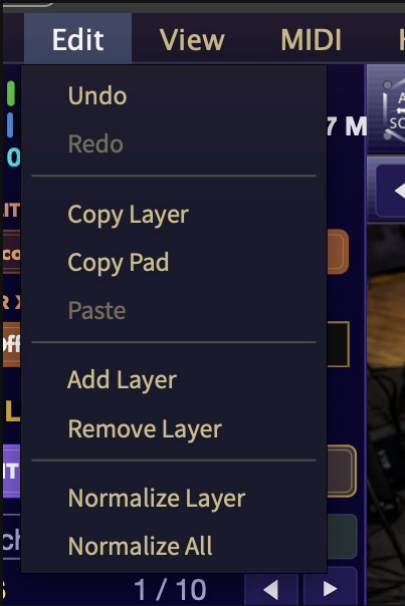


Fig A-1 Edit menu

Standalone only

Key	Action
Alt + F4	Quit the application
Windows + ↓	Minimise the window

B

TROUBLESHOOTING

Troubleshooting

The plugin won’t appear, no sound — the sticking points are usually the same few. They’re listed by symptom, in the order you’d check them.

What the Help menu can do

From Help in the menu bar you can do the following.

Item	What happens
About Groove Activator...	Shows the version and copyright
License...	Shows your Machine ID once activated; opens activation if not
Open User Manual	Opens this manual as a PDF
Visit GOTA RECORDS Website	Opens the store in your browser
Contact Support	Opens an email with the address, version and Machine ID already filled in
Acknowledgments...	Shows the third-party software included
Unused Samples...	Counts samples not referenced by any kit
Downloads...	Opens the downloads page in your browser (add-on sounds and updates)
Ask AJITO Assist...	Opens the support page in your browser
Check for Updates on Launch	Turns the launch-time check on or off (off to begin with)
Check for Updates Now...	Checks once, there and then

NOTE Some DAWs will not let a plugin open a browser. When that happens the URL is shown instead - copy it and paste it into your browser.

Being told about a new version

Groove Activator can tell you when a new version is out. It is off to begin with. The first time you launch it, a band appears along the bottom of the drum photo — “Notify me when a new version is released?” — with Yes and No thanks. Pick one; it is asked only once.

NOTE Closing without answering counts as No thanks. Nothing reaches the network unless you say Yes. You can change your mind later with Check for Updates on Launch in the Help menu.

With Yes, the plugin reads a small version file on the internet at most once a day when it starts. A badge appears only when there is something newer; pressing it opens the downloads page in your browser. It never downloads or installs anything by itself.

NOTE What it reads is the version number, the page URL and a short note of what changed. Nothing identifying you is sent. It gives up after five seconds and says nothing at all when it fails, so it stays out of your way where there is no connection.

NOTE To check on the spot, use Check for Updates Now... in the Help menu. That works whether the launch-time check is on or off.

The plugin does not appear in the DAW

Try these in order. Step 1 or 2 solves it in most cases.

1. Quit the DAW completely and open it again. A DAW that was open during installation cannot see the new plugin yet. Your DAW looks for new plug-ins at startup, so the next launch may take a little longer while it checks the plug-ins you own. That is normal.
2. Run a plug-in rescan from your DAW's settings. Most DAWs have a rescan button in their Plug-in Manager or VST plug-in preferences.
3. Check that the files are in the install locations (the table in Ch.3). Also make sure C:\Program Files\Common Files\VST3 is in the list of folders your DAW scans for VST3 plug-ins. If you kept an older Groove Activator.vst3 somewhere else as a backup, your DAW sees the same plug-in twice and may get confused. Move the spare out of the folder and try step 1 again.
4. If it still does not appear, restart your PC and try steps 1 and 2 once more.

NOTE Sometimes the installer was stopped by SmartScreen and nothing was installed at all. If you see “Windows protected your PC”, click “More info” and then “Run anyway” (see Ch.3).

License activation error

If “Invalid serial number.” appears, double-check what you typed (copy & paste from your email is most reliable). If activation was lost because the Machine ID changed after a PC repair or a Windows reinstall, choose Contact Support from the Help menu. An email is created with the address and your Machine ID already in it - just send it and we will take it from there.

No sound

Check, in order: is Master Mute ON, is the Master Volume turned down, is the kit loaded correctly, and is MIDI input arriving?

END MATTER

C

CREDITS

Credits

In making Groove Activator v1.5.1 Queen Edition, I was supported by many people and technologies. My heartfelt thanks to everyone who offered valuable advice, testing and encouragement during development, and to all those who provided such wonderful technology.

Development

Concept, Design, Development, Programming: Gota Yashiki. Operations, Beta Testing, Web/Social: Ho-To Musuko (Ogata-san).

Technology

JUCE Framework: Raw Material Software. SoundTouch: Olli Parviainen. PACE Eden SDK: AAX Copy Protection.

D

ABOUT AJITO SOUNDS

About AJITO SOUNDS

AJITO SOUNDS is the sound brand of GOTA RECORDS, based in a studio housed in a renovated storehouse (kura) in Ayabe, Kyoto.

The origin of “AJITO”

“AJITO” means a hideout, a base for creation. As the culmination of days spent shuttling between London and Tokyo, it is where I now pursue my ideal of sound-making, in a storehouse in Ayabe, Kyoto.



Fig D-1 Slice Activator artwork — the core feature of AJITO SOUNDS

Artwork by Toshio Nakanishi (Plastics / Melon). In loving memory.

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E

COLOPHON

Colophon

Legal

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